

Vol. 4, No. 1 & 2
Winter 2023

Left Turn

A Quarterly Journal of Critical Voices



Who Are We?

Robert Jensen

**Faramarz Farbod interviews
Ervand Abrahamian on protests in Iran**

Reflections on Being American

Elaheh Farmand

Let's push for a radical labor movement in 2023

Michael D. Yates

US/China War Is No Longer Unthinkable

Gary Olson

Mike Davis on becoming a Marxist

Editor: Faramarz Farbod

Associate editor: Peter Crownfield

Contributing editors: Chuck Daniels, Elaheh Farmand, Alex Fischer, Robert Kocis, Ted Morgan, Phillip Riess, Sakura Shinjo

Left Turn is sponsored by the Beyond Capitalism Working Group of the Alliance for Sustainable Communities—Lehigh Valley. Contact us at leftturn@sustainlv.org. *Left Turn* welcomes comments from readers.

© 2023 Alliance for Sustainable Communities—Lehigh Valley

This work is licensed under the Creative Commons NonCommercial-ShareAlike 4.0 International License. (For terms, see creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-sa/4.0)

Individual works are also subject to copyright by the author.

Notes from the Editor

The denial of the right of the Palestinian people to self-determination is arguably the very heart of the injustice in Palestine. Most north Americans are unaware that Article 55 of the Charter of the UN recognized this right in the aftermath of World War Two. It states in part: “With a view to the creation of conditions of stability and well-being which are necessary for peaceful and friendly relations among nations based on respect for the principle of equal rights and self-determination of peoples, the United Nations shall promote: ...” Furthermore, Article 56 states that “All Members pledge themselves to take joint and separate action in co-operation with the Organization for the achievement of the purposes set forth in Article 55.” Clearly the violation of this pledge by Member States is one reason for the unrealized right of the Palestinian people to self-determination. Another is the US obstruction and rejectionism in relation to the Palestinian national aspiration.

On September 21, 2022, the UN released a welcome Report by the Special Rapporteur, Francesca Albanese, about human rights in the occupied Palestinian territories with a special analytical focus on the right of self-determination. (See the link for the full Report: <https://documents-dds-ny.un.org/doc/UNDOC/GEN/N22/598/03/PDF/N2259803.pdf?OpenElement>) The UN Secretary General transmitted to the General Assembly the report titled “Situation of human rights in the Palestinian territories occupied since 1967.” Israel did not permit Albanese to enter occupied Palestine, thereby continuing its long record of non-cooperation with the previous UN Special Rapporteurs in particular and with human rights defenders in general.

Three generations of Palestinians in the occupied territories, 40% of whom are 1948 refugees and their descendants, still wake up every day under the yoke of Israel’s domination. Many of them have been displaced once more during the 1967 war. Israel continues to violate numerous Palestinian rights, including the right to self-determination and the right of the refugees to return, restitution, and compensation.

The UN report identifies three dominant approaches to the question of Palestine: humanitarian (improving certain aspects of life under occupation), political (ending the occupation through “negotiated peace agreement” between the opposing sides), and

(continued on page 80)

Contents

Notes from the Editor.....	ii
Who Are We? Robert Jensen	2
Faramarz Farbod interviews Ervand Abrahamian on Protests in Iran	10
US/China War Is No Longer Unthinkable Gary Olson	12
Becoming a Jew Without Borders Joel Beinin	17
You Should Thank this Russian Naval Officer that You and Your Loved Ones Are Alive Today Jeremy Kuzmarov	22
Let’s push for a radical labor movement in 2023 Michael D. Yates	26
Can The Left Disagree Without Being Disagreeable? Vijay Prashad ..	30
Climate Collateral Mark Akkerman, Deborah Burton, Nick Buxton, Ho-Chih Lin, Muhammed Al-Kashef, Wendela de Vries	32
Mike Davis on becoming a Marxist Mike Davis	36
Who Would Kill the Gander that Goosed a Golden Egg? Don Fitz ...	41
Forever Young: Staughton Lynd Andy Piascik	46
Capitalism, the Absurd System: A View from the United States John Bellamy Foster & Robert W. McChesney	49
Reflections on Being American Elaheh Farmand.....	60
Two Barrels Aim at African People’s Socialist Party Don Fitz	64
Christians as Dangerous Good Samaritans Gary Olson	68
The Homestead Steel Strike Lenny Flank	72
Stand in solidarity with our Councilmember (Versus voices of white supremacy/death...) Raymond Nat Turner.....	76
Hair in the game... Raymond Nat Turner.....	78
Arab American & Palestinian American Leaders Meet With US Secretary of State Anthony Blinken	81

Contributed work expresses the views of the creators and does not necessarily represent the views of the Alliance

Original writing, drawings, photographs, and other creative work are subject to the creator’s copyright and may be used only with permission of the artist.

Who Are We?

ROBERT JENSEN

Editors' Note: This is the Introduction to the book An Inconvenient Apocalypse, by Robert Jensen and Wes Jackson.

In the many phone conversations between the authors when this book was under construction, one of us would say that a particular point was so important that we need to get it right up front. After a few of these comments, we joked that there were so many things that needed to be right up front that the book was getting top heavy and would be impossible to hold open.

The first thing we want to put right up front is this: we are two old white guys from the United States living pretty comfortably with good retirement plans. We believe it's important to start with recognition of who we are in social terms, a signal that we are not tone deaf to the political climate in which we write. We understand why some readers might be reluctant to consider the work of people from certain classes and identity categories, especially if people in those classes and categories so often have been reluctant to fess up to our own failures, individual and collective.

Our intention is to continue in this blunt fashion rather than avoid uncomfortable questions. Throughout this book, our goal is to confront difficult issues as honestly as we can, even when our analysis might create tension with friends and allies. We believe this approach is more necessary than ever at this all-hands-on-deck point in human history. We ask readers to bear with us while we explain our sense of urgency, our approach to analyzing the crises, and what we believe are our best options for the future. We offer this advice on intellectual engagement from John Steinbeck:

We had had many discussions at the galley table and there had been many honest attempts to understand each other's thinking. There are several kinds of reception possible. There is the mind which lies in wait with traps for flaws, so set that it may miss, though not grasping it, a soundness. There is a second which is not reception at all, but blind flight because of laziness, or because some pattern is disturbed by the processes of the discussion. The best reception of all is that which is easy and relaxed, which says in effect, "Let me absorb this thing. Let me try to understand it without private barriers. When I have understood what you are saying, only then will I subject it to my own scrutiny and my own criticism." This is the finest of all critical approaches and the rarest.

We do not claim our arguments are flawless, and we hope readers who identify a flaw will not dismiss immediately the soundness of the larger analysis. We will suggest that there are patterns at work in the world quite different from what many people believe. We encourage readers to scrutinize and criticize after engaging our arguments in the easy and relaxed fashion advised by Steinbeck. We agree that such a

critical approach is rare, because we can reflect on how often we have taken the other two routes in our lives. As we get older, we hope we have gotten better at being relaxed.

Contemporary Crises

There are many different ways to categorize and analyze the threats that humans have created and cannot evade much longer. Reasonable people can disagree about details, but for the moment let's focus on the big picture. The following summary would get wide agreement not only in progressive political circles but also in much of mainstream society and even parts of more conservative political communities.

First, within the human family, we face a struggle for social justice in societies that currently do not operate in a manner consistent with widely held values concerning dignity, solidarity, and equality. Many people, whatever their political affiliation, express a commitment to (1) the inherent dignity of all people, (2) the importance of solidarity for healthy community life, and (3) the need for a level of equality that makes dignity and solidarity possible. But living according to those moral principles is hard, and the impediments are well known: the sexual and social subordination of women and girls under patriarchy; the brutal history and corrosive contemporary practices of white supremacy; wealth inequality and deprivation in unjust economic systems, most recently capitalism; and global inequality rooted in historical colonialism and today's economic imperialism. If we can't align our dysfunctional politics and destructive economics with those widely held values, we are in trouble.

Second, we face a struggle for an ecologically sustainable relationship between humans and the larger living world, the ecosphere. That means dramatic changes—in both the way we think and the way we live—are necessary in societies that draw down the ecological capital of the ecosphere beyond replacement levels. This will require a shift away from the widely accepted idea that Earth exists for humans to exploit without much regard either for other organisms or for the long-term health of the ecosystems that sustain us. The threats here also are well known: human-centric economic systems and cultural norms that have for millennia led to soil erosion and degradation, and in recent centuries have produced chemical contamination of land and water, a steep decline in biodiversity, and climate destabilization. If we can't align our living arrangements with the laws of physics and chemistry, we are in trouble.

From those basics on which many agree, disagreements emerge pretty quickly about details, even among like-minded people. These conflicts often are the result of different core ideologies or different locations in the social structure. But we think this is a reasonable general summary of the challenges we face in achieving social justice and ecological sustainability.

How are we to proceed? We should consider possible actions in the context of multiple cascading crises—three words we would like to etch into everyone's consciousness. The concurrent and unpredictable failures of social systems produce short-term threats that demand a response immediately, as well as long-term threats that will not be resolved anytime soon and perhaps cannot be resolved. We do not face discrete problems that can be solved in isolation. We have to struggle to understand all of these destructive forces and how they interact so that our actions will be as effective as possible. All of these threats demand everyone's immediate attention, yet no one person can act on all fronts in any given moment or even in a lifetime. In

view of all that, it is not surprising that many people find it easy to lose hope that the necessary change will happen in time.

Abandoning such hope is reasonable, an assertion to which we return at the end of the book. But for now, we want to point out that there's no sense pretending these threats are not overwhelming simply because we wish they were more manageable. It's fine in a love song to suggest that "the impossible will take a little while," but in real life the impossible is just that, impossible. Where does that leave us? The task is to recognize what is impossible and what is—or at least might be—possible, not in the abstraction of theory, but in the concreteness of the world.

The coming decades are likely to be marked by dramatic dislocations as a result of our social and ecological crises. We say "likely," because no one can predict with precision next week's weather, let alone the exact trajectory of human societies in the coming decades. Still, we believe that feeling some despair in the face of these threats is a rational, reasonable, and responsible reaction. Such despair—not over our personal fates but our species' collective inability to value the larger living world—should be pondered, not waved away with platitudes. We do not advocate nihilism, but we take seriously the biophysical limits of the ecosphere and human limits. It's cowardly to say that nothing can be done. It's silly to say that we can do whatever we set our minds to. If we stop fantasizing about doing the impossible, we can focus on doing the best job we can to achieve what is possible. The two of us continue to spend a considerable amount of our own time focused on analyzing and responding to these threats, well aware that positive outcomes are not guaranteed. Analysis (no matter how grim) and action (no matter how slim the chances of success) are antidotes to despair, though we are not pretending it is simple to determine what is possible and what is impossible, or what the most effective personal and policy choices might be.

So here's another thing that needs to be right up front: it is highly unlikely that the destructive forces unleashed by humans over the past ten thousand years since the invention of agriculture will be stopped in time to avoid what might be called apocalyptic consequences. Don't worry, that's not a lead-in to rapture talk. We use the term "apocalyptic" in a secular sense, as we explain in chapter 3. Because we remain engaged in the struggle and hope others will too, we want to suggest another way to approach crises, a way to organize our thinking that sharpens rather than obscures our understanding of the impediments to the deep changes necessary.

We come back to those three crucial words—multiple cascading crises—that remind us that the task is not to solve separate problems but to see the failure of systems and recognize the limits of our ability to predict how those failures will play out over time. Given the scope of that task, we are going to need what the geologist T. C. Chamberlin called multiple working hypotheses. In an essay first published in 1897, Chamberlin warned that a single "ruling theory" can too easily lead us to ignore evidence that disproves the conventional wisdom or supports an alternate explanation. In our context, that means we should beware anyone selling an easy way out, a way for us to have it all without dramatic changes.

If we are to respond creatively and effectively, we also need to think at both the material and ideological levels—the tangible and the intangible, the way we live day to day and the way we think about the meaning of our lives. At the material level, we face a crisis of consumption. In aggregate terms, the human population has too much stuff. That stuff is not equally or equitably distributed among the population, of

course. But no matter what the level of fairness and justice in societies, the ecological costs of the extraction, processing, and waste disposal required to produce all that stuff is at the core of our ecological crises. And by "stuff," we mean not just what everyone would agree are luxury items but also much of what many people believe are necessities (more on this in chapter 4). Collectively, we have to learn to live with less in the aggregate, no matter how resources are distributed. In some sense, this is easy to understand and should motivate us to change course. But those who already have too much stuff typically have trouble reducing the rate of acquisition, and those without much stuff typically seek to get in on the acquisition game.

A major reason that societies across the globe find it difficult to imagine reducing aggregate consumption is because at the ideological level we face a crisis of meaning. Human philosophical and theological belief systems vary widely, of course, and there are countless insightful answers to the search for meaning in our lives. We are not arguing that everyone is leading a meaningless life; many people have grappled with the question and embraced answers that work for them and their communities. But whatever particular system one endorses and whatever answers individuals have come to, those choices have not equipped US society (or very many other societies) to deal with the multiple cascading crises as a society. Most of us have pondered the foundational human question, What does it mean to be a human being?, and come to some conclusions, however tentative. But we have no collective answer that has yet been able to help us deal effectively with the problems of social justice and ecological sustainability.

The two of us have no one-size-fits-all solution to the crisis of consumption and no platitudes to offer to resolve the crisis of meaning. We recognize that if the human species cannot deal with the crisis of consumption—that is, if we cannot collectively impose limits on what we take from Earth—the human future is bleak. And such limits will be impossible to impose if we cannot respond to the crisis of meaning, which requires either adapting traditional philosophical and theological systems to the new challenges or transcending those systems when they fail us.

We speak as citizens of the United States, which is appropriately our focus, but are aware that these challenges apply in many places today. The dominant culture needs to accept changes in the way we live and in the way we think about being alive, and to do that we need to get past comforting illusions about what kind of animal we are and what kind of world we live in. We need to come to terms not just with human nature, but with human-carbon nature (see chapter 1).

So, Who Are We?

That takes us back to what we put right up front: we are two old white guys from the United States living pretty comfortably with good retirement plans.

Again, that is simply a way of saying that we recognize the need for critical self-reflection about identity, especially in this political and cultural moment. We realize that much of our success is not the product of unusual effort or extraordinary intelligence. Both of us have tried to use our abilities to the fullest, but obvious advantages have come our way because we were born white, male, in the United States, during a period of rapid economic expansion. If we had been born good-looking, we would have had it all.

We know that people who look like us sometimes believe ourselves to be more important than we are; sometimes speak when we should listen; sometimes overestimate the value of our contribution and demand that others pay attention to us. Still, we believe that we have something to say that is of value to everyone. We hope that readers of this book—whether they agree or disagree with the various analyses and conclusions—will find that we offer reasonable ideas that are important to consider in the face of the difficult choices in front of us. We recognize the need for humility about our limits, but we are confident that we have something valuable to offer, based on decades of work in a variety of intellectual and political arenas.

On humility: Throughout our lives we have had access to resources that we have not earned and have been accorded status in the world that cannot be justified, all as a result of the accident of when, where, and to what parents we were born. There are good reasons that some readers might be skeptical about what we have to say or might even challenge whether at this moment in history we should be speaking at all. After all, it's mostly white guys, young and old, who got us into the various messes we're in.

On confidence: In our combined 150 years (when this book is published, Jackson will be 86 and Jensen, 64), we have studied in a variety of disciplines and intellectual traditions, and we have been active in a variety of political and social movements. We have spent considerable time and intellectual energy pondering pressing questions.

We each have a contrarian streak, but we aren't writing in search of controversy for its own sake. We don't critique conservatives to appeal to liberals, nor do we challenge progressive ideology just to shore up our credentials with the mainstream. We fit somewhere on the left side of the political fence, so we have learned to expect the conservative resistance that comes our way. But we also challenge progressive assumptions and know from experience that some of these conclusions will be rejected on the left. We also are supporters of modern science, so we expect pushback from the critics of that tradition. But we also make claims that challenge Enlightenment dogma.

We perhaps have gone on too long here, but we want to make it clear that this book is born out of a sense of responsibility, not entitlement, out of a sense of urgency to face the multiple cascading crises. For a good chunk of our adult lives, both of us have been subsidized to do intellectual work—defined here simply as collecting and assessing evidence to try to identify patterns in the world, the attempt to understand how both physical and social systems work. We've had access to good schools, first-class libraries, and conversation with lots of smart people all over the world, which have informed our teaching, writing, and activism. We're grateful for everything those things have brought to our lives and believe we should make responsible use of those advantages.

And here's the irony. We have a lot of running room to be as blunt as necessary because we are financially stable and don't have to worry about losing our jobs, and we are old enough that we don't much care about risking whatever status we've acquired over the years. As T. S. Eliot put it in "East Coker," "Old men ought to be explorers." We take seriously Eliot's charge that we "must be still and still moving / Into another intensity." We can say what we think needs to be said, especially when it challenges the positions taken by friends and colleagues who may bristle at our intensity. If we thought the analyses of the political and intellectual movements of which we are a part were 100 percent correct, we would have no reason to write. We wish that were the case, but it's not.

What We Believe

We aren't going to march readers through the volumes of research demonstrating the depth of the social disparities and the severity of the ecological dangers. A parade of statistics and studies rarely persuades those who have decided to ignore the threats to human communities and ecosystems. This book takes those disparities and dangers as a starting point.

To anchor us in the depth of those threats, consider this warning from 1,700 of the world's leading scientists:

Human beings and the natural world are on a collision course. Human activities inflict harsh and often irreversible damage on the environment and on critical resources. If not checked, many of our current practices put at serious risk the future that we wish for human society and the plant and animal kingdoms, and may so alter the living world that it will be unable to sustain life in the manner that we know. Fundamental changes are urgent if we are to avoid the collision our present course will bring about.

That statement was issued in 1992. Because such concerns were ignored by the people in power, in 2017 a follow-up report, "World Scientists' Warning to Humanity: A Second Notice," was issued. This time, more than 15,000 scientists from 184 countries made the case: "We are jeopardizing our future by not reining in our intense but geographically and demographically uneven material consumption and by not perceiving continued rapid population growth as a primary driver behind many ecological and even societal threats."

For a quick summary of the threats, a 2020 report from the Commission for the Human Future, a nongovernmental and nonpartisan group of researchers and citizens, identified ten catastrophic risks that require immediate attention.

The decline of key natural resources and an emerging global resource crisis, especially in water;

The collapse of ecosystems that support life, and the mass extinction of species;
Human population growth and demand, beyond the Earth's carrying capacity;
Global warming, sea-level rise, and changes in the Earth's climate affecting all human activity;

Universal pollution of the Earth system and all life by chemicals;
Rising food insecurity and failing nutritional quality;
Nuclear arms and other weapons of mass destruction;
Pandemics of new and untreatable disease;
The advent of powerful, uncontrolled new technologies;
National and global failure to understand and act preventively on these risks.

The implications of these warnings, which so far have gone largely unheeded not only by those in power but also by the dominant culture more generally, are clear. If we don't transcend a growth economy, there are hard times ahead. And if we do manage to construct a new economic order, there are hard times ahead. Hard times are coming for everyone, even though some people are more responsible for social and ecological problems than others and some of those people will be able to evade the consequences of those problems, at least in the short term.

The task of creating new systems is daunting, in large part because of challenges posed by the nature of the human animal, combined with most people's denial of what it means to be an animal. We have faith in the better angels of our nature but

realize that those better angels alone won't save us from what we call "the temptations of dense energy," which has come most recently in the form of fossil fuels. We conclude that there are no workable solutions to the most pressing problems of our historical moment. The best we can do is minimize the suffering and destruction. We conclude that the human future—even if today's progressive social movements were to be as successful as possible—will be gritty and grim. And yet we continue to search for ways to make whatever changes are possible, not just out of moral obligation, but in the pursuit of a more joyful participation in the Creation.

We like the term "Creation" for the sense of reverence that it brings, even though we don't believe in a creator god. But we see creativity and ongoing creation all around us, every day, in the ecosphere. We have affection and respect for religious traditions but are critical of the dogma that those traditions so often produce. And we get just as nervous when secular traditions drift into dogma, as they regularly do. We work hard to monitor our own thinking to avoid overdriving our headlights, well aware that the human weakness of claiming certainty in the face of complexity lies in wait for us just as much as for others.

No matter what their identity, all authors should ask before writing, "Is another book really necessary?" We ask ourselves, "Is another book by us necessary?" Our answer for this project is obviously "Yes," because many people are looking for an honest account of the human condition at this tenuous moment in history, one that does not give up on the obligation to act but also does not turn away from the inevitable grief when we confront our limitations. We believe that the claims we make in this book—especially the ones that might make some people bristle—are not only defensible, but crucial to consider if there is to be a decent human future, perhaps if there is to be a human future at all.

Same and Different

Right up front, we made it clear that self-reflection about identity is important. Most people today accept that things like sex, race, class, and national status are relevant in shaping people's ideas. But within those categories, there is considerable individual variation. In the interest of full disclosure, a bit more about Jackson and Jensen, not simply in terms of identity categories, but individual biographies. While we share a similar social position, like any two people we are not the same. We come from different backgrounds, with quite different experiences. We ended up with very similar views of the world but got there on quite different paths.

First, the similarities. Jackson is from Kansas and Jensen is from North Dakota, midwestern states whose economies are dependent on agriculture, though Kansas is three times more populous and more racially diverse, with a more diversified economy and larger cities. The political histories of both states include periods of progressive populism, though in recent decades both have shifted to the political right. Neither state has ever been thought of as cosmopolitan. There's an old joke in Fargo, North Dakota, that when the end of the world finally comes it will be good to be in Fargo, because everything arrives there ten years late. And what's the go-to movie line when you find yourself in a new and exciting place? "Toto, I have a feeling we're not in Kansas anymore," Dorothy says to her dog in *The Wizard of Oz*. Neither of us grew up in what could be called intellectual families, and neither of us was raised with expectations of living a life much different from the people in our communities.

Both of us got into professional intellectual life not through careful career planning but by stumbling into graduate school when we weren't sure what else to do, and both of us have taught college students (Jackson, at Kansas Wesleyan University and California State University, Sacramento; Jensen, at the University of Minnesota and the University of Texas at Austin).

Second, the differences. Jackson was a farm kid (from North Topeka) born during the Great Depression (1936), and Jensen was a town kid (from Fargo) born during the post-World War II boom (1958). Jackson was a jock focused on football and track, while Jensen was equally inept in all sports. Jackson's education and career grounded him in the sciences—biology, botany, genetics. Jensen's education and career grounded him in social sciences and humanities—communication, philosophy, law. Jackson's focus has been on agriculture and environmental policy, involving many years of traveling and public speaking in the United States and internationally. Jensen has focused his organizing activity on issues of sex, race, and foreign policy, both at the local and national levels.

What all this adds up to is that we are perhaps best described as progressive hicks. In intellectual and political terms, we would be described as progressive left. In cultural terms, we are hicks, not only because of our rural or small-town background but also because we still feel comfortable in those places. Jackson left university life early and returned to Kansas to cofound The Land Institute, just outside Salina, which remains his home. Jensen made university teaching his career before retiring early to the edge of a small town in northern New Mexico, glad to have escaped city life. Another way to say this is that both of us are radical in our approach to analyzing systems of wealth and power and conservative in lifestyle.

We see today's multiple cascading crises as the product of systems—not just the social, political, and economic systems of the past few centuries, but the hierarchical ways of organizing human relationships with each other and the world that have been widespread for the past few millennia. We don't much like hierarchy unless there's a compelling justification for it, and we have rarely run into such justifications. That's the radical part.

In our day-to-day lives, we shy away from too much change too quickly and are uncomfortable with much of what is considered "cutting edge" in today's world. We are both hesitant about new technologies, uncomfortable with having too much leisure time, and skeptical about anything trendy. That's the conservative part.

The similarities tend to outweigh the differences, so in most of the book, we speak in a single voice when presenting our analyses. We conclude by writing separately to explore how our personal experiences have influenced our sense of hope.

That's who we the authors are. Our next task is to talk about we the human species.

*Jensen is host of "Podcast from the Prairie" with Wes Jackson and associate producer of the forthcoming documentary film *Prairie Prophecy: The Restless and Relentless Mind of Wes Jackson*.*

Jensen can be reached at rjensen@austin.utexas.edu. To join an email list to receive articles by Jensen, go to <https://www.thirdcoastactivist.org/jensenupdates-info.html>. Follow him at @jensenrobertw (Twitter), @RobertJensen@newsie.social (Mastodon), and @robertjensen (Post).

Faramarz Farbod interviews Ervand Abrahamian on Protests in Iran

Faramarz Farbod: Ervand, I wanted to get your view on the current social movement in Iran known as “Zan, Zendegi, Azadi” in Farsi, which translates into “Women, Life, Freedom.” We are into 4 months of this protest movement. More than 500 people have been killed, apparently. The state has executed four persons. Another at least 14 or so are apparently on a list for being executed. Many people in the Iranian opposition abroad are talking about “revolution” and “regime change,” and so on. The Iranian government on the other hand has a different discourse altogether. It blames foreign enemies — Israel, Saudi Arabia, the United States — and news outlets like Iran International, BBC Persian, etc. for the unrest or what it calls “riots.” So, let’s hear your point of view. I’m eager to know what you’re thinking about all of this.

Ervand Abrahamian: I think what is happening now actually relates to what had happened before. It was during the 1979 revolution that the dominant discourse was that of Islam. I think that discourse has become bankrupt. It doesn’t mean that everyone has disbanded it, but I think that instead of having 80% or 90% of the public talking about Islamic discourse, it has probably shrunk to about 15% to 20%. And with that bankruptcy of Islamic discourse, partly because Islamic discourse has turned out to be a velayat-e faqih discourse (Khomeini’s concept of the rule of the guardian jurist), which was never really that popular. But once it’s been revealed that Islamic discourse is clerical discourse, that has shrunk the appeal of it.

What has really emerged, or re-emerged, is the Enlightenment discourse that had existed in Iran from 1900 to the 1960s—basically individual rights, whether it’s the right of a woman to decide whether they wear a veil or not, or the right to be able to vote for the candidates you want, listen to the music you want, wear the clothes you want—these are basically individual rights that go back to the Enlightenment. And none of the basic religions, including Islam, accepted individual rights. But I think people—especially even people who have been raised under the Islamic Republic, gone to Islamic kindergartens, primary school, secondary school, colleges, universities—have embraced this concept of individual rights. They may not have read Voltaire or Diderot, but instinctively they feel that they can choose for themselves what they want. They don’t want a cleric to decide for them. And this actually since there is a whole history of Enlightenment approach in Iran that goes back to the pre-Islamic discourse.

I think this has become really a major threat to the Islamic Republic. It may not lead to a revolution, but it has created a permanent crisis for the regime, because the regime is still talking about a clerical discourse while the majority of people are not interested in that discourse. They are interested in the discourse that really goes back to individual rights.

FF: Also, there seems to be a lifestyle clash, perhaps a cultural clash, pitting the state prescribing its preferred lifestyle against many, especially among the young, who reject the state sanctioned way of life.

EA: Yeah. I mean, what I’m surprised by all these protests, except for in Baluchestan (the Sistan and Baluchestan province is in the southeast of the country, bordering Pakistan and Afghanistan), religion is not an issue. Even in Kurdistan (a province located in the west of Iran), it is a Sunni population, but they are not talking about religion, or true or false religion. They are talking about individual rights.

FF: In your view, is Khomeinism in the form that we’ve been discussing it, that is as velayat-e faqih, compatible with reformism of the kind that some people in Iran are still hopeful about, and who reject the idea of revolution? I’m asking whether Khomeinism as such is compatible with the concept of rights, the rule of law, and other ideas and practices that come out of the enlightenment tradition.

EA: I think some Islamic reformers, like the former President Mohammad Khatami (1997-2005), moved very close to the Enlightenment without actually openly embracing it. They tried to reinterpret Khomeinism in a way that it would include individual rights. But they have been marginalized. They failed. I think that has also shown the bankruptcy of the Islamic discourse, that the reformers have failed and been marginalized. I think that creates a crisis situation for the regime because it makes it hard to say that the system can somehow reform itself. It may have been possible under President Khatami, or even under the previous President Hassan Rouhani (2013-21), but it is not a feasible alternative under the current President Ebrahim Raisi.

FF: Do you think that future elections might open a path towards reformism?

EA: That could only be possible if there was someone, a very pragmatic leader, who would backstep and do it. But I don’t see that happening either with President Raisi, or with Ali Khamenei (the current supreme leader of Iran), or anyone from their entourage, because I think they have become tighter and tighter as time has progressed, and the alternative would be some sort of a pasdar regime (an informal name for the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, IRGC) rather than a reformist regime.

FF: Finally, could a renegotiated Iran nuclear deal help in this regard?

EA: Well, I do not see it happening because I do not think President Raisi’s government, or Khamenei, is interested in that.

FF: Ervand, thank you for your time.

Dr. Ervand Abrahamian, emeritus distinguished professor of modern Iran’s history and of the Middle East. He has taught at Oxford, Columbia, and the Baruch College, City University of New York. He is the author of many books on Iran, including Khomeinism, A History of Modern Iran, The Coup, and most recently Oil Crisis in Iran. He is currently working on a book about the 1979 revolution.

Faramarz Farbod, a native of Iran, teaches politics at Moravian University. He is the founder of the Beyond Capitalism working group of the Alliance for Sustainable Communities-Lehigh Valley and the editor of its publication Left Turn. He can be reached at farbodf@moravian.edu.

Watch the full interview with Dr. Abrahamian on BCTV. [\[www.youtube.com/watch?v=xn5kRMeY20E\]](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xn5kRMeY20E)

US/China War Is No Longer Unthinkable

GARY OLSON

China offers a threatening alternative model of development that is non-capitalist, non-Western, and non-colonial. As such, it undermines the West's neocolonial domination of the Third World and its debt-trap-based forced underdevelopment of subservience and exploitation. — *K.T. Noh*¹

If the United States were to posit that it could eliminate the economic challenge from China by launching an atomic war, there is no evidence that would not do so. — *John Ross*²

A Sino-American war is no longer unthinkable. As we approach a very dangerous period, possibly including WWII and nuclear catastrophe, I fully expect a rise in frenzied Sinophobia, threat inflation, vile lies about China, and further efforts to limit advanced technology to Beijing.

Here, I'm fantasizing that if blessed with the talent to write a dystopian, geopolitical, political thriller (with an edge-of-your seat movie to follow) I'd pitch a prospectus along the following lines:

In the not-too-distant future, the fears of the U.S. bourgeoisie are borne out when a multipolar, poly centric international political system takes shape. China has become a global economic player, its Belt & Road Initiative won massive appeal throughout the global South and Beijing's call for respecting the rights of all people to choose their own economic and political system has won many friends. A formable "Front of the South" is clearly on the horizon. China has also taken the lead in fighting climate change and despite the U.S. best efforts, its computer chips are among the best in the world. In short, "Socialism with Chinese characteristics" will have proven its superiority to neoliberal capitalism.

As K.T. Noh writes, China has demonstrated that it has developed an alternative, non-Western, capitalist, model of development without wars, invasion, colonization, slavery, regime change, primitive accumulation—that the world can emulate and follow.³ Clearly, the U.S. ruling class cannot allow this 21st century threat of a good example to come to fruition and will use any means available to prevent it.

A win-win world future is inconceivable to the ruling class. They are unwilling for the United States to become just another normal country even though that would be inestimably better for ordinary citizens. As background, a two-pronged strategy emerged: first with Obama's "pivot to Asia" in 2011 and then, in 2014, the U.S. manipulated coup d'état and Minsk agreement in Ukraine which overthrew a democratically elected president and installed a puppet regime. Washington then baited and provoked Russia into military intervention in Ukraine in 2022.⁴

U.S. military planners pursued their medium-term objective of weakening and even dismembering Russia to deny China its key geopolitical ally and force it to face the US on its own. The proxy war that the U.S. launched against Russia in Ukraine and is fighting to the last Ukrainian mercenary, showed the world that Washington

was willing to engage a Great Power—but the conflict ended in a stalemate. As the Pentagon anticipated, Russia was weakened but regime change was not achieved, and Putin remains in power. China, even with its extended Covid pandemic, pledged a "comprehensive strategic partnership of coordination" with Moscow.

Given its military supremacy and with a vast array of bases and well over 100,000 military personnel encircling China, Washington is sorely tempted to use its military to compensate for its inexorable economic decline and to halt China's development—before it's too late. An ominous unknown is what Russia will do if a war with China should "go nuclear."

American officials publicly accuse China of repeatedly violating the "ruled-based international order" but behind the scenes these same officials are heard to say, "We are an empire, albeit a benign one, and this is an American linguistic instrument designed to preserve us as a global hegemon." She added that the rules protect US interests as its power wanes relative to China." Besides, as another official candidly explains, "This is not about nations following rules, but the one indispensable nation is making and imposing certain rules on behalf of safeguarding the free world."⁵

The mass media begins amping up its China bashing and accuses the Chinese president of being evil incarnate, another Hitler. Slowly by slowly this drumbeat of propaganda succeeds in manufacturing consent for a war on China.

The likely flashpoint for military confrontation is the South China Sea and a Gulf of Tonkin-type incident is concocted by the CIA and the Pentagon. This is followed by U.S. B21's and anti-ship missiles destroying a substantial portion of China's maritime shipping assets. Because the U.S. is overextended in terms of military supply lines, its efforts to block Chinese trade routes and disrupt oil imports are only partially successful but U.S. submarines do manage to sink several ships attempting to sneak in and out of Chinese ports. The People's Liberation Army (PLA) retaliates by attacking American warships and bases in Guam, South Korea, and Okinawa, causing tens of thousands of U.S. military personnel to perish.

A protracted military conflict ensues and in the fog of World War III, a "red line" is crossed when the Washington initiates the use of battlefield tactical nukes. The national security establishment counts on Beijing not having a survivable nuclear deterrent after absorbing a U.S. first strike. Thus, Washington's credible nuclear threat (6,500 warheads) will prevent further escalation and compel China's subjugation to U.S. global supremacy. However, due to hubris and miscalculation, a thermonuclear exchange results in which cities in both China and the United States are vaporized. Firestorms cause radioactive fallout unfurling in a massive plume extending some 60 miles from the blast sites. Both sides lose this geopolitical conflagration and in Washington, the long knives are out, and recriminations begin.

India, which steadfastly refused to condemn Russia's invasion of Ukraine, turned to Moscow as its largest oil supplier and rejected a Western world order, ascends to global leadership.

Bearing the above in mind, we know my book proposal will remain stillborn. However, that was not the fate of a speculative fiction novel appearing last year with the intriguing title, *2034: A Novel of the Next World War*, by Elliot Ackerman and James Stavridis (New York: Penguin Press, 2021). It quickly rose to New York Times

Bestseller list and received generally positive reviews across the mainstream political spectrum. Efraim Habers, former head of Israel's Mossad, praised the book and described China as a "Great Threat" to the United States. And both former Secretary of Defense Robert Gates and General James "Mad Dog" Mattis call the book a "realistic cautionary tale for our times." I wouldn't be surprised if Netflix film is already in the casting stage.

As you've undoubtedly surmised, here the wily, arrogant Chinese Communist Party instigate war with the United States. Beijing uses its vastly superior cyber warfare dominance to lure an American battleship into an ambush. China then sinks a flotilla of 37 US warships in order to gain a goal "generations in the making," —unfettered control of the South China Sea. Meanwhile, Iran seizes an F-35 out of the sky —again, using superior technology—and the pilot is taken hostage. China then sets about annexing Taiwan.

As long as Beijing refrains from engaging with ICBMs, the U.S. president orders a "limited" multi-pronged attack on the Chinese mainland including striking the Chinese port of Zhanjing with a 150 kiloton "tactical" nuclear weapon. A "red line" is crossed. China responds by creating radioactive wastelands of San Diego and Galveston and the US president (a female) retaliates by vaporizing Shanghai in a mass murder (no other term suffices) of 30 million people. The authors write that the devastation in Shanghai "exceeded capacity for comprehension." The book ends with India intervening as the peacemaker with the New Delhi Peace Accords. The price of the war had been staggering to both countries and in its wake, India becomes the world's ascendant political and economic juggernaut and Iran also emerges in a highly advantageous position.

Dr. Sandeep "Sandy" Chowdhury, the US deputy national security adviser, despairs that Reagan and Kennedy's vision of a "city on a hill" might now perish but reassures himself with the thought that "America was an idea and ideas very seldom vanish..." American was a nation of "freemen" and he fervently hopes that this spirit of America has "yet to abandon the place."

The authors blame defeat of the storied "city on a hill" on enormous deficiencies America's technological war fighting readiness which must be shored up before it's too late. The fact that the U.S. does not prevail is meant to rattle readers (and officials) out of their complacent stupor. And related, the question hangs in the air whether the U.S. can vanquish the China threat without resort to nuclear weapons? The authors also muse whether the U.S. public will waver in its support for war after hostilities begin?

It would never occur to the authors, publishers, reviewers or indeed, the American people, that the US would be the aggressive party and initiate military conflict with China. As one of book's characters muses, "America didn't use to start wars. It used to finish them." And in a recent interview, the book's authors reveal their American exceptionalism bias when they assert that "The history of America is us striving to create a more perfect union—to hit that ideal...the essence of America is that enduring ideal, and worth investing in and it has brought us much more good than harm to this world."⁶

In the novel, China is portrayed as seeking to replace the U.S. as the globe's most powerful country. In testifying before the Senate Armed Services Committee

in March of 2021, Admiral Phil Davidson echoed this message when he said that China might attempt a military takeover over Taiwan in the next six years and this is "just one step along the way to supplanting the United States and its leadership in a rules-based international order." Taiwan only bookends a larger war. Davidson added that China will militarily "attempt unilaterally changing the status quo."⁷ And the Pentagon's 2022 China Military Report to Congress, meant to convince that body to grant the largest defense budget ever, warns that China may challenge the U.S. in the global arena.

In lieu of a conclusion, I think of a quote attributed to Albert Einstein that "The world is dangerous not because some people do evil but because some people see it and do nothing" and bookend it with Howard Zinn's that our problem is too much civil obedience.

However, I'm not sanguine about enough disobedient forces rising up in the United States in time to take up the gauntlet of Einstein's "something." And I must confess that, at times, I find myself on the edge of despondency as I sense the morbid symptoms in our midst that foreshadow WWII, even before the climate Apocalypse.

Along with others on the left, I've often cited Gramsci's injunction about "pessimism of the mind, optimism of the will" as the only answer for those committed to struggle for justice in the world. That is, I'm convinced that we must look at the United States as it actually exists, with no illusions about the future. Noam Chomsky terms this RECD or "really existing capitalist democracy—which in its basic nature is a death sentence." In the face of this reality, Chomsky has consistently reminded us that a moral person has only two choices: To do nothing to stop evil in the form of our belligerent warmongers who are bent on initiating war with China. This choice guarantees the worst will occur. Or we must do whatever we can to stop the Merchants of death "which is not much of a choice, so we should be able to easily make it." This course may not prove cathartic, but it will put us more in touch with our humanity and that's no small thing.

Gary Olson is Professor Emeritus at Moravian University, Bethlehem, PA.

Contact: garyleeolson416@gmail.com

Endnotes

1 K.J. Noh, "The U.S. Is Set on a Path to War with China. What is to be Done?" <https://www.quicollective.com/articles/what-is-to-be-done>

2 John Ross, "What is Propelling the United States into Increasing International Military Aggression," *Monthly Review*, April 24, 2022. And see, Wi Yu, "What the Pentagon Doesn't Want You to Know About China," *Common Dreams*, Dec 20, 2022; Deborah Veneziale, "Who Is Leading the United States to War?" <https://mronline.org/.../who-is-leading-the-united-states...>

3 Koh, op.cit.

4 Benjamin Abelow, *How the West Brought War to Ukraine* (Great Barrington, MA: Siland Press, 2022).

5 Paraphrased from quote by the invariably astute political analyst Kim Petersen, "What is the Rules-Based Order?" <https://www.thehttp://greenvillepost.com/.../what-the-rules-based-order/...>

6 Ethan Locke, "2034" Authors talk about World War III, Nuclear Conflict and America's Future," *Coffee or Die*, April 14, 2022.

7 USNI News, March 9, 2021.

Editor's Note: The author provided the following additional notes after the preceding essay was accepted for publication.

A recent article in Nikkei Asia was headlined “Analysis: Xi left turn to a real socialism is for real.” Katsuji Nakazawa, a senior staff writer, gets it right about Xi but wrong when he goes on to describe this as a radical departure from and repudiation of Deng Xiaoping’s pro-market reforms from an earlier era.

Deng argued that China was in the early or primary stage of socialism in 1970s and early 1980s and that this stage can’t simply be leapfrogged over. He said, “Our principle is that we should integrate Marxism with Chinese practices and blaze a trail of our own. That is what we call socialism with Chinese characteristics.” (Deng, 23, August 1985) For their part, Marx and Engels were under no illusions and knew this would be a prolonged transition and achieved “by degrees.” For Deng, the “principled contradiction” has been between imbalanced growth and people living better, more productive lives.

Adopting elements of the market economy in 1978 was a step on the road to socialism and post-Deng policies have been consistent with this analysis.

We know that a chasm of wealthy distribution remained in the wake of the China’s rapid economic growth. Under Xi, the redistributive role of the state—the next stage—has begun targeting tax evasion by wealthy elites, correcting property market excesses, shedding negative Western cultural influences, banning private tutoring companies (which give the edge to wealthy families), cracking down on online gaming, reigning in tech giants like Alibaba and Tencent and the CPC exerting more control over private enterprise. The CPC is serious about realizing “common prosperity” by the target date of 2050.

More recently, in the face of slowed economic growth, China has expediently rolled back some regulatory reforms and officials have adopted language that’s more business friendly. Some commentators (even self-identified leftists) gleefully pounce on this as evidence that China is “even more capitalist than the United States.” However, savvy foreign investors understand that while some short-term profits are available, China’s approach to private business has turned a corner. They grasp, as Oxford University professor Rana Mitter asserts, that Xi is serious about steering China toward socialism and bringing back “the sense of mission that shaped early Maoist China.”

There are no guarantees that this will work. In China, as elsewhere, people will not wake up one fine Spring morning and discover that socialism has bloomed overnight. This is a developmental process that operates in the real world, not in the fervid minds of critics who ask: “Has socialism arrived there?” Furthermore, China’s modernization will continue to antagonize powerful elements within China who are living large. And of course, it threatens U.S. hegemony and the international system that Washington has established to service the empire. Finally, China’s path will be arduous enough without caviling from those who should be steadfastly anti-imperialist, international allies.

Becoming a Jew Without Borders

JOEL BEININ

I grew up in an intensely Jewish but secularist and Zionist family for whom Jewish identity and survival were central concerns. In the foreground of my earliest memories of thinking about my identity is a profound feeling of not belonging in America because of my Jewish commitments. Perhaps my sense of difference began because until I was four my parents and I lived with my maternal grandparents in South Philadelphia, where the language of the home and most of the Jews in the neighborhood was Yiddish. I knew no one else my age who spoke Yiddish, which I regret having lost after my grandparents died and I had no one with whom to speak it.

Soon after my father graduated from the University of Pennsylvania, like many upwardly mobile Jews, we moved to North Philadelphia. Our neighborhood was almost entirely Jewish. I had one non-Jewish friend, a Catholic, who could not attend my Bar Mitzvah in accord with pre-Vatican II church rules. The Thomas K. Finletter School, which I attended from first to eighth grade, was located on the boundary between my neighborhood and a heavily German neighborhood sometimes known as the “new Third Reich” because support for Hitler had been widespread there in the 1930s. There were many conflicts between the Germans and the Jews in and around school.

Going to school was often an exercise in asserting my Jewish identity. I spoke out against singing Christmas carols in school assembly and reading from the Bible in class daily (some of my Christian classmates made a point of choosing passages from the New Testament that are especially offensive to Jews). Despite my parents’ secularist outlook, they encouraged me to absent myself from school on every Jewish holiday and to attend synagogue every Saturday and holiday. Unlike many of my friends, I attended Hebrew school enthusiastically and was deeply engaged in studying Hebrew and Jewish history.

The most vivid memory of my elementary school years is of an oral report I gave on the trial of Adolf Eichmann in eighth grade together with another Jewish classmate. We were proud that the organizer of the mass murder of our people had been apprehended by Israel and his crimes exposed to the world. Perhaps there was also a vengeful tone in our account of the Jerusalem trial. Following our presentation, as the class was preparing to go to lunch break, a girl of German ancestry bitterly proclaimed, “Hitler made only one mistake.

He didn’t kill all the Jews.” Our teacher and principal tried to convince the Jewish students that, “She didn’t mean it,” and above all not to tell our parents about it. This did not avert a very heated lunch period.

At the age of ten I began to attend the summer camp of Hashomer Hatzair (The Young Guard)—a socialist-Zionist youth movement affiliated with the MAP AM party in Israel (now a component of MERETZ) that trained its members to emigrate to Israel and join kibbutzim where we would achieve self-realization and form the vanguard for a future socialist Israel. The message provided an explanation for my experiences and feelings of alienation from the United States. Before my first summer was over, I resolved that this was the correct path for me (and indeed for all Jews).

I became deeply involved in the organization, especially after my family moved to New Jersey in 1963 and I could travel to weekly meetings in New York. Eventually, I became director of the Queens branch, a head counselor at summer camp and responsible for educational programs in the national leadership.

Consequently, I was only superficially involved in the political and cultural upheaval of the 1960s. We members of Hashomer Hatzair thought of ourselves as more serious than the American new left. We professed a clearly articulated ideology: “Zionism, socialism, and brotherhood of peoples”; we believed in the redemptive value of physical labor and prided ourselves on the ability to do practical things; and we rejected consumer culture, rock music, make-up, dating, and smoking in favor of a youth culture emphasizing simplicity, scouting skills, and intense emotional bonding to the collective. We participated in the civil rights and anti-Vietnam War movements, but usually with the feeling that we were trespassing in American politics because we were soon going to live in Israel. This attitude was encouraged by our emissaries from Israel, who argued that we should not participate in demonstrations against the Vietnam War because we were leaders of an educational movement whose focus was Israel. Subsequently I realized that they also opposed the anti-militarist sentiment of the demonstrations.

During the summer of 1969 I took an intensive Arabic course at the American University in Cairo. In the dormitory I met several Palestinian Arab students who were studying English. Within the spectrum of Zionist opinion, Hashomer Hatzair had the most accommodating attitude towards Arabs, so I was predisposed to get along well and to listen respectfully to their views about the Arab-Israeli conflict. Their insistence that they were part of a Palestinian Arab national community was jarring, but I could not deny the sincerity of their convictions. This was my first step away from the milieu of Hashomer Hatzair.

After graduating from Princeton and getting married in 1970, I went, together with my wife and our group of about 60 veterans of Hashomer Hatzair, to live in Kibbutz Lahav in the northern Negev desert. My first job on the kibbutz was as a cowboy. On horseback or in a jeep, I tended a herd of beef cattle that ranged over much of the 2,500 acres occupied by the kibbutz. This forced me to confront daily the situation of the kibbutz on the lands of three former Arab settlements—Zag, Umm Ramamim, and the sedentarized Laqiya al-Asad bedouin. Two of the Laqiya al-Asad worked as wage laborers for the kibbutz in the field crops branch, despite the official prohibition on wage labor in the kibbutz, farming lands that they had formerly claimed as their own. They ate lunch every day in the communal dining hall with the other members of the kibbutz. But often they sat alone at a table for six because most kibbutz members avoided eating with them despite the social norm that all tables should be filled in order.

Later I worked tending the turkeys of the kibbutz, a job which I disliked because turkeys are stupid and vicious animals and because my coworker, the manager of the turkey branch, was something of an Israeli Archie Bunker. Our most onerous task was to shovel the manure out of the sheds after mature birds had been sent to market as part of the process of preparing the sheds to receive new three-day-old chicks. Once we decided to experiment with a new technique for this process: chemically disinfecting the old manure so that it would not have to be removed after each cycle of birds. The procedure failed, and as a result we were under great pressure to

remove the manure manually before the new birds arrived. I suggested that we ask the kibbutz work organizer to give us some temporary extra help because we would not be able to complete the job on time by ourselves. He responded, “This is not work for Jews, this is work for Arabushim” [the modern Hebrew equivalent of niggers applied to Arabs]. The next day a crew of Arab laborers appeared and cleared out the manure—a flagrant violation of everything I had been taught and taught others about the meaning of “Zionism, socialism, and brotherhood of peoples.”

These experiences, and many others involving gender relations, attitudes toward the military, and the blind opposition of most of the kibbutz members to those aspects of American culture that we inevitably brought with us despite our conscious rejection of that culture, led my wife and me to leave the kibbutz and move to Jerusalem in the early summer of 1971. I was deeply disappointed by the realization that the kibbutz was not the vanguard of social change in Israel, but still committed to living and being politically active in the country. Continuing the academic interests of my undergraduate years, I enrolled as a graduate student in the Department of History of the Islamic Countries at the Hebrew University in Jerusalem (the Israeli practice of locating Islamic and Jewish history in departments separate from general history is a manifestation of a problem whose full dimensions I appreciated only much later). At the same time, I joined a largely student political organization called Israeli New Left (SIAH) which focused primarily on the Palestinian-Israeli dispute and organized some of the first demonstrations against Israeli settlements and confiscations of Palestinian land in the West Bank.

That summer a group of Moroccan Jews from Jerusalem slum neighborhoods formed the Black Panther organization, consciously invoking the militant example of the African-American group of the same name, to protest the second-class status and discriminatory treatment of Middle Eastern Jews in Israel. We supported them, and in December 1971 SIAH participated in a large demonstration called by the Black Panthers in front of the Binyanei Ha-Umah convention center where the World Zionist Congress was convening. It was then virtually impossible to demonstrate legally in downtown Jerusalem. We had asked for permits for several demonstrations and had been told we could only demonstrate in distant suburbs. Consequently, most demonstrations in Jerusalem were illegal, as this one was. We students marched from the university to the convention center where we found the police dispersing the demonstrators using clubs and water cannons. As we were dodging the police and trying to remain in the area I said to a friend, “The police are really making me angry. In another minute I’m going to pick up a stone and throw it at them.” I was immediately arrested by an undercover agent and spent two weeks in jail before I was charged. The written report of the police stated that I had been standing on a car and directing the crowd to throw stones at the police.

Before the academic year was over, I was arrested once again for demonstrating and once for handing out leaflets. I was distributing Arabic leaflets in East Jerusalem. Since this was territory annexed by Israel it was subject to Israeli law and not military law. Leafleting did not require a permit, but because I was appealing to Arabs the police treated me like an Arab, though only temporarily, since I was released after a short time.

After my third arrest, I was called into police headquarters and informed that I was being charged with causing death by negligence in an incident that had occurred

at the Swedish Village, an institution for the developmentally and emotionally disabled where I had worked during the summer between leaving the kibbutz and starting graduate school. One of our patrons had run away, and I had been directed by my supervisor to search for him in the hills surrounding the institution. I was not on the premises when a physically disabled man was badly burned by hot water in the shower after someone had changed the temperature of the water. He had been screaming for help because he could not move away from the shower head on his own. My coworker was chatting with a friend in a different building when this occurred, and I discovered what had happened when I returned from my search in the hills. I took the burned man to Hadassah Hospital, where he died several days later.

An investigation was conducted at the time of this incident, and I was cleared of all responsibility. My supervisor covered up for my coworker, who should have been on the spot when the accident occurred. It was generally assumed that this was because they were both religiously observant. The institution was operated by the Ministry of Interior, which was then in the hands of the National Religious Party, and that's how things worked.

Nine months later, the case was reopened, and I was charged with responsibility for the death. My Israeli political friends had no doubt that this was because of my political activity. I had been exceptionally active and visible because I was a new immigrant, but fluent in Hebrew—an unusual combination. I consulted a lawyer about my case who advised me that he could not promise that I would not spend three years in jail.

This was one of the major factors in my decision to leave Israel early in 1973. I might have been prepared to go to jail for a political charge, but not for a criminal charge. No Israeli lawyer would have been willing to argue in court that the state was conspiring to stop my political activity. In any case, doing so would have increased the likelihood of my conviction.

On October 21, 1967, I participated in a demonstration to surround the Pentagon and stop the U.S. war machine in Vietnam, an event idiosyncratically portrayed by Norman Mailer in *The Armies of the Night*. Like most of those present, I had little idea how this was going to be accomplished. As we reached the Pentagon, I found myself just outside a side door where, not knowing what else to do, we sat down. Moments later a phalanx of U.S. marshals charged out of the building wildly swinging clubs. A marshal's club split open the head of a man next to me, and he fell into my arms bleeding. The shock of seeing that innocent blood and trying vainly to arrest its flow remains with me as an emblem of the arbitrary and unjust power of states. At this moment I understood that U.S. policy in Vietnam and everything that was done to enable it were unredeemably evil, and I saw no alternative but resistance.

The Israeli police taught me that the Jewish state had no less capacity for exercising arbitrary power and committing injustice than the American state. Moreover, I came to feel that Israel was not a very Jewish place. The elements of the Jewish tradition with which I identify and from which I draw sustenance are the social ethics of the prophets who fearlessly criticized kings, the commitment to free inquiry and liberation of human potential exemplified by Spinoza, Marx, Freud, and Einstein, the values of the Jewish labor movement emerging from the immigrant experience in New York's lower east side, and the commitment of Jews like Michael Schwerner and Andrew Goodman to the civil rights movement because they understood, as James

Baldwin wrote to Angela Davis, "If they take you in the morning, they will be coming for me that evening."

Despite the nominal values of labor Zionism, in practice this has not been the dominant social ethic in Israel. In the early 1970s, when more Israeli Jews verbally embraced it than do now, most of them fell easily into uncritical acceptance of almost anything done in the name of national security, especially when it came to Palestinians and other Arabs. It was only in Israel that I came to understand that my commitment to this heritage was both an expression of my Jewishness and of how American I really was after all.

It took a long time to integrate my experience in Israel into my scholarly activity. When I proposed writing a doctoral dissertation on the formation of the Palestinian Arab working class during the British Mandate my advisor at the University of Michigan told me that this would be a fine topic, but that if I wrote on Israel or Palestine, I would never get a teaching job. Several incidents during my graduate career made this seem plausible, so I wrote on the history of the Egyptian labor movement instead. Indeed, when I first lectured at Stanford on the subject of my dissertation, which had little to do with Arab-Israeli issues, someone in the audience asked why I had referred to the Arab-Israeli War of 1948-49 as the Palestine War. Even the word was a problem. "That's what the sources I used call it," I replied meekly.

Israel's invasion of Lebanon in 1982, belatedly opposed by a very large proportion of the Israeli intelligentsia, reconfigured political and intellectual life in Israel and made it possible for Jews and Israelis to discuss the meaning of Israel in ways not entirely constrained by the boundaries of official Zionist discourse. The school of new Israeli historians, including Ilan Pappé, Gershon Shafir, and Avi Shlaim, has begun to develop approaches to the history of Israel and the Arab-Israeli conflict that challenge the national foundation myths. Engaging in dialogue with these friends and colleagues has increased my confidence in Israel's capacity to become a much better place than it is now. Gershon Shafir has insightfully argued that much of what is distinctive about Israel emerged as a consequence of the conflict with the Palestinians. My experience in Israel would certainly have been very different if the state had not come into existence through a process that dispossessed the Palestinian Arab people.

My recent book, *Was the Red Flag Flying There? Marxist Politics and the Arab-Israeli Conflict in Egypt and Israel, 1948-1965* is an effort to come to grips with the history of Israel, and the nature of the Arab-Israeli conflict. It assumes that both the Arab and the Jewish communities of Palestine/Eretz Israel have equal rights to self-determination and security and seeks to explain the failure (so far) of those who have sought to resolve the conflict on this basis. My current research project, "The Dispersion of Egyptian Jewry" is a study of the Egyptian Jewish community in the 1950s and beyond. A sympathetic exploration of ways of being Jewish in the past that have been ignored and minimized by the Zionist national narrative may suggest that there are also alternatives for the future.

Joel Beinin is the Donald J. McLachlan Professor of History and Professor of Middle East History, Emeritus at Stanford University, and a non-resident fellow at DAWN. He is the author of several critical books on politics of the Middle East and North Africa.

This essay first appeared in 1993 in Stanford Humanities Review.

You Should Thank this Russian Naval Officer that You and Your Loved Ones Are Alive Today

JEREMY KUZMAROV

Let's hope there are more Vasily Arkhipovs out there today—we need them now more than ever

On October 27, 1962, Soviet naval officer Vasily Arkhipov helped prevent the outbreak of World War III and saved humanity from nuclear catastrophe.

A minesweeper during the Pacific War, Arkhipov was the commander of a diesel submarine that had been sent by Soviet Premier Nikita Khrushchev to escort merchant ships bound for Cuba, which were equipped with a torpedo boat armed with a nuclear warhead.

On October 14, 1962, a U.S. spy plane flying over Cuba had revealed that the Soviet Union was building ramps for the installation of missiles with nuclear warheads, in retaliation for the United States deploying missiles with nuclear warheads capable of striking the Soviet Union in Italy, at Gioia del Colle (Apulia in southern Italy), and in Turkey.

President Kennedy's imposition of a naval blockade after the spy plane discovery triggered the 13-day Cuban Missile Crisis, during which time the submarine that Arkhipov commanded was being pursued by U.S. destroyers which, using depth charges, were trying to force Arkhipov's submarine to the surface.

After the Soviet sub's ventilation system broke down and communication was cut, the captain of the Soviet submarine group, Valentin Grigoryevich Savitsky, was convinced that war had broken out.

Not wanting to sink without a fight, he decided to launch a nuclear warhead at the aircraft carrier pursuing his sub.

The political officer, Ivan Semyonovich Maslennikov, agreed with the captain, but on the flagship B-59, Arkhipov's consent was also needed, and he objected, convincing Savitsky ultimately to do the same.¹

Arkhipov's persuasion averted a nuclear war, whose consequences would have been horrific. After surfacing, Arkhipov's sub was fired on by Americans but was able to return to the Soviet Union safely.

Spooked about how the world had come so close to the nuclear brink, President Kennedy gave a speech at American University in June 1963, five months before his



Vasily Arkhipov [Source: warhistoryonline.com]

assassination, calling for a "reexamin[ation of the U.S.] attitude towards the Soviet Union" and "Cold War" and for the U.S. and Soviets to work together for a "just and genuine peace" and to "halt the arms race."

"Confident and unafraid," Kennedy concluded, "we must labor on—not towards a strategy of annihilation but towards a strategy of peace."

Another Grave Moment of Danger

Defense Secretary Robert S. McNamara was not mincing his words when he said years after the events that "We came very, very close [to nuclear war during the Cuban missile crisis,] closer than we knew at the time."

Arthur Schlesinger, Jr., characterized the period of the Cuban Missile Crisis as "not only the most dangerous moment of the Cold War [but] the most dangerous moment in human history."

That moment of danger unfortunately appears just as sharp today.

Time Magazine reported in late October that Russia's launching of missile strikes targeting energy plants within Ukraine and civilian infrastructure "triggered fears that hostilities were escalating and inching closer to nuclear war."

The U.S. had stoked the fire by a) engaging in provocative military drills testing the handling of thermonuclear bombs; b) delivering bombers to Europe equipped with low-yield tactical nuclear weapons; and c) carrying out acts of international terrorism such as the sinking of the flagship vessel of the Russian Black Sea Fleet called the Moskva that prompted Russian President Vladimir Putin to place Russia on high nuclear alert.

The U.S. was generally the one to provoke a new Cold War with Russia by a) expanding NATO towards Russia's border; b) imposing economic sanctions on it under fraudulent pretexts; c) and then backing a coup in Ukraine that triggered the conflict in eastern Ukraine which has evolved into a proxy war.²

In October 2018, the Trump administration pulled the U.S. out of the 1987 Intermediate-Range Nuclear Forces (INF) agreement, characterized by former U.S. ambassador to Russia Jon Huntsman, Jr., as "probably the most successful treaty in the history of arms control."³

Carl J. Richard, head of the U.S. Strategic Command (STRATCOM) which oversees the nation's nuclear arsenal, wrote in the U.S. Naval Institute's monthly magazine subsequently that the U.S. military had to "shift its principal assumption from 'nuclear employment is not possible' to 'nuclear employment is a very real possibility,'" in the face of threats from Russia and China.

Richard's successor, Anthony J. Cotton, said just as ominously during his confirmation hearing in September that his job was to prepare the 150,000 men and women under his command to deploy nuclear weapons, and that the president should have flexible nuclear options.

Both Richard and Cotton appear to be of the opposite character of Arkhipov, whose level-headedness under pressure and commitment to peace between the U.S. and Russia needs to be remembered at this time.

In a deeply Russophobic climate, Arkhipov should remind us also not to associate Russians with the stereotyped qualities promoted about them in Hollywood films—and in the ravings of Pentagon war planners and politicians who have led us into another grave crisis.

Jeremy Kuzmarov is Managing Editor of CovertAction Magazine. He is the author of four books on U.S. foreign policy, including Obama's Unending Wars (Clarity Press, 2019) and The Russians Are Coming, Again, with John Marciano (Monthly Review Press, 2018). He can be reached at: jkuzmarov2@gmail.com.



[Source: gasedal.wordpress.com]

Endnotes

- 1 See Ron Ridenour, *The Russian Peace Threat: Pentagon on Alert* (New York: Punto Press, 2018), chapter 5.
- 2 See Jeremy Kuzmarov and John Marciano, *The Russians are Coming, Again: The First Cold War as Tragedy, the Second as Farce* (New York: Monthly Review Press, 2018).
- 3 See Scott Ritter, *Disarmament in the Time of Perestroika: Arms Control and the End of the Soviet Union* (Atlanta: Clarity Press, 2022) on the lost promise of the disarmament treaties of the late Cold War era.



JFK giving commencement address at American University in June 1963 in which he spoke for a rethinking of the Cold War and need for disarmament. Five months later, he was assassinated. [Source: pinterest.com]



President Kennedy with the Joint Chiefs of Staff during the 1962 Cuban Missile Crisis. [Source: freedomrockradio.co]

Let's push for a radical labor movement in 2023

MICHAEL D. YATES

The year 2022 saw a significant increase in working-class unrest in the United States. Millions of workers quit their jobs in 2021, and this trend has continued in 2022. Most moved on to different employment, while others continued their education or retired. Recently, many Twitter employees quit in response to the severe force reduction and intensification of work effort engineered by new owner Elon Musk. For those working, there has been a wave of what the media has dubbed “quiet quitting,” but which is really an old-fashioned labor strategy known as “working to rule,” or doing no more than what you have been ordered or contractually required to do. Those working from home have shown a reluctance to return to the office, an indication that, despite the problems of laboring where you live, offices are seen as worse.

Union organizing is on the rise, reflecting both the widespread disgust with workplace conditions and the now evidently positive public view of labor unions. The purchasing power of wages has stagnated for decades in the United States, while labor's productivity has risen considerably. Unfortunately, the latter is partly the result of employer-initiated speed-ups, meaning that fewer workers must take up the slack created by a smaller workforce—again, management-created. According to Gallup, 71 percent of Americans now approve of unions, the highest favorable rating since 1965. This may help explain the surge in union recognition efforts. Between October 1, 2021 and June 30, 2022 (fiscal year 2022), union certification petitions at the National Labor Relations Board (NLRB) were up 58 percent over the previous year. No doubt there were other such efforts, those that simply petitioned employers to bargain with a union or where workers struck to win bargaining rights. Because employers regularly violate the law by committing unfair labor practices (ULPs) such as firing union supporters, the NLRB has faced a heavy caseload of ULPs, which rose 16 percent over the same period.

People are forming unions across a wide array of occupations, including adjunct college professors, farmworkers, grocery store personnel at Trader Joe's, baristas at Starbucks, laborers at Amazon warehouses, Google cafeteria workers, delivery drivers, Apple employees, staff at restaurants such as Chipotle, chocolate makers at Hershey's, clerks from Dollar General to Williams-Sonoma, autoworkers and video game designers. In every case, it is the arbitrary, arrogant, impersonal and condescending treatment of employees that has motivated this organizing. Workers are rejecting their treatment as mere commodities—controlled, spied upon, used up, sped up and expected to devote their lives to making money for those who own their workplaces. They are demanding dignity in addition to higher wages, shorter hours, benefits, and safe working conditions. The Amazon and Starbucks efforts have garnered the most publicity, with the latter showing a spectacular increase in union victories. Since the first Starbucks store was unionized in Buffalo, New York, in December 2021, workers

at more than 250 locations have voted to unionize. Chris Smalls, the leader of the Amazon Labor Union (ALU), has become a national celebrity.

Three things stand out in these union recognition campaigns. First, “salting” has been a useful tactic. “Salts” are organizers trained by a labor organization to obtain employment in a non-union workplace and use their skills to begin a union organizing drive. It takes great skill to do this work, with the salt always risking discovery. The Inside Organizer School was formed by famed organizer Richard Bensinger and others in Silver Spring, Maryland, to train salts. A longtime organizer, who prefers to remain anonymous, informed me that those trained have gone into workplaces across the country, including the Starbucks stores first organized in Buffalo.

The second notable trend: Some workers are forming independent unions, untethered from the traditional unions in the AFL-CIO and other established labor groups. The independent ALU is one significant example. The Workers United union at Starbucks is relatively independent, but it is affiliated with the Service Employees International Union (SEIU). Recently, an independent labor union was formed to organize service-sector workers in the South, the Union of Southern Service Workers. Naomi Harris, who attended the founding convention, said:

We are going to fight by marching up on the bosses with our petitions, striking at the right time, getting community support for rallies. We will organize walk outs, sit-ins, and boycotts if we need to. We will take legal action against wage theft because you're not about to pay me less than I deserve and take money out of my tips at the same time. We're going to fight and fight and fight until we get what we deserve.

The push for independence reflects the lackluster organizing record of most AFL-CIO unions, their close ties to the pro-business Democratic Party and their top-heavy, highly paid bureaucracy, which is often mired in corruption.

Third, many of those supporting and leading these organizing struggles are young, knowledgeable, and downwardly mobile. The informant mentioned above, who is radical in his politics and deeply involved in multiple organizing drives, told me that these workers are keen to learn about the history of labor in the United States. They have been absorbing the insights of long-forgotten labor champions like William Z. Foster, who led the heroic fight to organize the steel industry in 1919. Through my informant, I have sent 400 copies of my book, *Why Unions Matter* to be distributed to various worker organizations across the country. I have sent my most recent book, *Work Work Work*, to labor studies programs in the United States as well. Education about the nature of our economic system, work and confronting employers is more critical than ever.

Increased organizing has complemented a greater willingness to strike, picket and boycott. Payday Report has tracked well over 1,000 work stoppages since the beginning of the pandemic in 2020. These have been mostly short walkouts, such as the strike by Starbucks workers this year on November 17, Red Cup Day, when the company gives out its much-loved reusable red cup for the holidays. However, there have also been larger and longer strikes. Hundreds of Alabama coal miners have been on strike for 20 months, supported by their communities and the United Mine Workers of America. The company, Warrior Met Coal, has continued to operate using scab labor.

In September, *The Guardian* reported:

Some of the largest strikes in recent weeks in the U.S. have included 15,000 nurses who went on a three-day strike in Minnesota, over 1,100 timber workers in Oregon and Washington, over 4,500 teachers and staff in Columbus, Ohio, more than 6,000 teachers and staff in Seattle, 2,000 mental healthcare workers in California, 1,200 casting plant workers at Stellantis in Indiana, and 700 nursing home workers in Pennsylvania.

More recently, 48,000 graduate student workers and academic researchers, represented by four unions, struck at the University of California (UC), frustrated after a year of trying to negotiate a collective bargaining agreement and the filing of more than 20 unfair labor practice complaints. One group reached an agreement but would not return to back to work until the other units settle. The other did reach agreement mid-December of this year. The walkout was very likely the largest academic strike in U.S. history and certainly the biggest strike this year for any workers. These workers do most of the teaching at UC campuses and help with much of the research, receiving inadequate pay and benefits in high-rent areas, much the same as their counterparts throughout the country. As higher education becomes just another business, those who do the hard labor find it difficult to consider themselves anything other than employees. The same is true for many professionals, including physicians, who have begun an organizing drive at Montefiore Hospital in the Bronx.

A strike is looming at UPS, one that could severely impact critical deliveries. Drivers, maximally stressed and overworked, are members of the Teamsters, now under new, forceful and more democratic leadership. We don't know whether there will be a railroad workers' strike, now that the federal government has callously legislated an agreement—one that has the odor of involuntary servitude—between the rail unions and the owners, an action supported by politicians claiming to be champions of the working class. Regrettably, one seldomly reported factor with respect to the rail unions is that most of their leaders are remarkably inept and have historically run their unions in an autocratic manner with little concern for the needs of their members. If ever an independent union, of all those toiling on the railroads, was needed, it is here.

There is a tendency on the left to see every working-class upsurge as a sign of the rebirth of a militant labor movement. While what I have described above is heartening, some historical perspective is necessary. In 2021, 10.3 percent of workers were unionized—with an astonishing 6.1 percent in the private sector—the same as in 2019. Total union membership is now 3.7 million lower than it was in 1983, when density was 20.1 percent. Density was very likely above 30 percent in the mid-1950s, and private sector density was almost surely higher 100 years ago. Major strikes (1,000 or more workers) have been in long-term decline, with 16 in 2021, down from 187 in 1980 and 470 (the highest on record) in 1952. These numbers may rise before 2023, but not enough to mark a sharp reversal in the trends. In addition, it is one thing to form a union, but is another to win a collective bargaining agreement. Amazon, Starbucks, Google, large universities etc. have deep pockets and labor laws that give them tremendous advantages in confronting unions. It will take great creativity and

solidarity within the working class to emerge triumphant and get better wages, hours and working conditions.

And even supposing union membership skyrockets and better contracts are achieved, this is not the same as building a labor movement aimed at radically changing society. Union leadership may change, as in the Teamsters and now very likely in the United Auto Workers, but this usually means, at best, some improvements in the terms and conditions of employment. It seldom changes the relations of production, that is, it leaves intact that which must be changed: The control of the workplace monopolized by those who own the means of production.

What is needed is a labor movement with strong principles; a radical education program; the will to attack the deepening control the powerful have over the way we labor and nearly every aspect of our lives, the grotesque inequality in wealth and the anti-labor bias of the political system. And, of greatest importance, the destruction of the environment, with global warming making labor an utterly unhealthy endeavor, must be confronted as the ultimate working-class issue. The time seems ripe for such a movement to develop. We can only hope that it will. That as young workers begin to learn the underlying nature of the forces dominating their lives, they will begin to take collective actions that allow them not only to challenge their employers but also to start the long and arduous process of organizing production and distribution themselves. We have examples: the many programs of the Black Panthers, urban agriculture, peasant organizing in rural India, the communes in Venezuela, Cooperation Jackson. A labor movement worthy of the name must embrace these, broadening and deepening them, building a new society in the shell of the old.

*Michael D. Yates was a labor educator and author of many books on union organizing, the labor process, and the working class, including *Why Unions Matter*, *Can the Working Class Change the World?*, and most recently, *Work, Work, Work: Labor, Alienation, and Class Struggle*.*

© Copyright 2022, [Truthout.org](https://truthout.org). Reprinted with permission.

Editors' Note: On January 12, 2023, a settlement was reached—three days after 7,000 nurses went on strike against the four major hospitals.

Can The Left Disagree Without Being Disagreeable?

VIJAY PRASHAD

I have been a reporter for thirty years. During this period, I have been to many former war zones and to active war zones, including in Iraq, Libya, and Syria. I have seen things that I wish I had not seen and that I wish had not been seen by anyone, let alone experienced by anyone. The thing about war zones that is often not talked about is the noise: the loud noises of the military equipment and the sound of gunfire and bombs. The sound of a modern bomb is extraordinary, punctuated as it often is in civilian areas by the cries of little children. Imagine the trauma inflicted upon generations and generations of children by the noise itself, not to speak of the neurological fear of the adults around them and the great loss of life that they experience from early in their lives. There is no war that should be supported based on the catastrophic cost paid by humanity for the violence.

There is no war that I have experienced that has been as devastating as the war on Iraq, which snatched the lives of millions, devastated the lives of the entire population, and left the country scarred beyond belief. No doubt other reporters who are in Ukraine will come with their own stories. There is no comparison of warzones, one more deadly than the other, although the sheer destruction of Iraq compares to the pain inflicted on Hiroshima and Nagasaki by the atomic bombs.

Wars are to be opposed and every effort must be made to prevent wars and to end wars.

So, to claim that I support the Russian war on Ukraine is against everything that I have said or done on the record. I oppose this war as I oppose every war, which is why I have written — since 2014 — for the need for negotiation and for the need for neighbors to find a way to live with each other. It is peculiar that a call for negotiation between Russia and Ukraine is now painted as a ‘talking point’ of Vladimir Putin rather than a gesture towards peace. That is the toxic nature of debate, including within the left, where anything that is not identical with what someone believes is pilloried as the absolute opposite position; the space for nuance and dialogue is being withered by this sort of attitude.

I posted a picture on social media about Zero Covid. Having lost family and friends in the COVID pandemic, beloved people who lived in countries that had failed their populations, I remain in awe of the three years of Zero Covid policy and practice of countries with efficient governments (such as in China). When I took that picture, I was in a hotel room, where I used the stationery and pen provided for me. I had to draw the Z for Zero twice, which made the Z darker. This extra dark Z was taken to mean support for Russia’s war in Ukraine. This is the absurd place we have entered, where such fantasies are peddled as fact, despite the public record of my arguments for an end to the war.

Second, the picture was interpreted as a sign that I am a full-scale supporter of the government in China and all its policies. To be sure, I am impressed by the Chi-

nese government’s many policies, such as the way it handled the pandemic, the way it has eradicated absolute poverty, and the way it has managed the social development of the population. If you compare China with India, you will have no problem seeing the impressive developments in the former. There is a noxious way in which Western media claims about China are taken as completely correct, and then these claims — often exaggerated — are put before one as a litmus test: what do you think about this or that policy of the Chinese government, and based on one’s answer, one is measured for one’s correct leftism. What is your view on Xinxiang? What is your view on Hong Kong? What is your view on Taiwan? I have never been interested in these kinds of litmus tests. I am interested in discussion and debate, not in treating left discourse as a multiple-choice exam where there is only one correct answer to every question. History is a bundle of contradictions; social policy is fraught with difficult choices: to believe that history is a sequence of questions with one pure answer is erroneous and it creates a fratricidal culture in the left. We need to be far more generous with each other, able to hold conversations without resort to insults and abuses.

Out of disagreement comes understanding. But out of malicious slander only comes disorientation.

*Vijay Prashad is the George and Martha Kellner Chair of South Asian History and Director of International Studies at Trinity College, Hartford, CT. Prashad is the author of many books. Vijay Prashad’s most recent book (with Noam Chomsky) is *The Withdrawal: Iraq, Libya, Afghanistan and the Fragility of US Power* (New Press, August 2022). He can be reached at: vijay.prashad@trincoll.edu*

This article first appeared in eurasiareview.com on December 21, 2022.

Climate Collateral

How military spending accelerates climate breakdown

MARK AKKERMAN, DEBORAH BURTON, NICK BUXTON,
HO-CHIH LIN, MUHAMMED AL-KASHEF, WENDELA DE VRIES

As the world's climate negotiators gather for their annual summit (COP27) in Egypt, military spending is unlikely to be on the official agenda. Yet, as this report shows, military spending and arms sales have a deep and lasting impact on the capacity to address the climate crisis, let alone in a way that promotes justice. Every dollar spent on the military not only increases greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions, but also diverts financial resources, skills and attention away from tackling one of the greatest existential threats humanity has ever experienced. Moreover, the steady increase in weapons and arms worldwide is also adding fuel to the climate fire, stoking violence and conflict, and compounding the suffering for those communities most vulnerable to climate breakdown.

The trajectory of military spending and GHG emissions are on the same steep upward curve. Global military spending has been rising since the late 1990s, surging since 2014 and reaching a record \$2,000bn in 2021. Yet the same countries most responsible for large military expenditure are unable to find even a fraction of the resources or commitment to tackle global heating.

Our research reveals the following:

- The richest countries most responsible for the climate crisis are spending more on the military than on climate finance
- The richest countries (categorised as Annex II in the UN climate talks) are spending 30 times as much on their armed forces as they spend on providing climate finance for the world's most vulnerable countries, which they are legally bound to do.
- Seven of the top ten historical emitters are also among the top ten global military spenders: in order of magnitude the United States spends by far the most, followed by China, Russia, the United Kingdom, France, Japan and Germany. The other three of the top ten military spenders — Saudi Arabia, India and South Korea — are also high GHG emitters.
- Between 2013 and 2021, the richest (Annex II) countries spent \$9.45 trillion on the military, 56.3% of total global military spending (\$16.8 trillion) compared to an estimated \$243.9 billion on additional climate finance. Military spending has increased by 21.3% since 2013.

Military spending increases GHG emissions

A 2020 report by Tipping Point North South estimated that the carbon footprint of the global militaries and associated arms industries was around 5% of the total global GHG emissions in 2017. By way of comparison, civil aviation accounts for 2% of global GHG emissions.

In terms of fuel consumption, if the world's armed forces were ranked together as a single country, they would be the world's 29th biggest oil consumer, just ahead of Belgium and South Africa.

Other estimates by CEOBS and Scientists for Global Responsibility (SGR) put the annual military carbon footprint at 205 million tonnes for the US and 11 million tonnes for the UK of carbon dioxide equivalent, with France accounting for about a third of the European Union's estimated 24.8 million tonnes.

There is no evidence that the military can be green

The armed forces of the richest countries increasingly boast of their efforts to address climate change, pointing to the installation of solar panels on bases, preparation of sea-level defences, and replacement of fossil fuels in certain military hardware. A closer look, however, suggests this is more hype than substance:

- In most national military climate strategies, reduction targets are vague and undefined. The UK's 2021 Defence Climate Change and Sustainability Strategic Approach, for example, sets no reduction targets apart from 'contributing to the achievement of the UK legal commitment to reach net zero emissions by 2050'.
- The military has been unable to find adequate fuel alternatives for the transport and equipment used in operations and exercises — which make up 75% of military energy consumption. Jet fuel alone accounts for 70% of the fuel used by the military, followed by naval propulsion and, to a lesser extent, land-based vehicles. The military faces the same challenges as the civilian aviation sector — alternative fuels are still too expensive, limited in availability and unsustainable.
- Most of the stated goals of 'net zero' are based on false assumptions — reliant on technologies such as carbon capture, that as yet do not exist at scale, or dependent on alternative fuels that have serious social and environmental costs.
- Meanwhile the military keeps developing new weapon systems that pollute even more. For example, F-35A fighters consume about 5,600 litres of oil per hour compared to 3,500 for the F-16 fighters that they are replacing. As military systems have a lifetime span of 30 to 40 years, this means locking-in highly polluting systems for many years to come.

Moreover, military alliances like NATO have been clear that they will not compromise military dominance in order to tackle climate change. Climate change, in different national security plans, remains as much a call for increased military spending to deal with this 'threat', rather than a challenge to reduce or rethink their operations.

Russia's invasion of Ukraine has super-charged military spending and emissions

Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2014, and especially the huge escalation since February 2022, has been used to approve major increases in military spending (and, therefore, GHG emissions), with no signs that either Russia or the 30-strong NATO alliance have even considered the climate impacts.

The European Commission anticipates a spending boost by its member states of at least €200bn, based on combining ad hoc extra funds and longer-term structural increases. The US has approved a record \$840bn military budget for 2023, and Canada in 2022 announced an extra \$8bn for the next five years. Russia has approved a 27% increase in military spending since 2021, which will bring budgets to a total of \$83.5bn in 2023. Climate goals have been quickly thrown out of the window when it comes to military objectives. In 2022 alone, 476 of the most gas-guzzling fighter jets, the F-35, have been ordered—24 for the Czech Republic, 35 for Germany, 36 for Switzerland, six extra for the Netherlands on top of prior orders, and 375 for the US.

The war is already diverting resources from climate finance to military spending. In June 2022, the UK shifted money from its climate finance budget to partially finance a £1bn military support package for Ukraine. The Norwegian government has paused all disbursements of development aid, including climate finance, to get an ‘overview’ of the potential consequences of the war in Ukraine.

The biggest winner of this military spending bonanza is the arms industry

The arms industry has boomed from the global increases in military spending, as well as from diversifying into sectors such as border control and immigration management. The European Defence Agency (EDA) reported in 2021 that ‘the procurement of new equipment has benefited most strongly from the overall increase in defence investments’ in recent years. After Russia’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine, and in particular the German announcement of €100bn extra spending, share prices of large arms companies have skyrocketed.

The richest countries are exporting arms to the most climate-vulnerable countries, fueling conflict and war amid climate breakdown.

- The richest (Annex II) countries accounted for 64.6% of the total value of international arms transfers (2013–2021).
- Annex II countries have exported arms to all 40 of the most climate-vulnerable countries. Thirteen of these countries are involved in armed conflicts, 20 have authoritarian regimes and 25 are among the countries with the lowest levels of human development. Some of them are also subject to UN and/or EU arms embargoes (Afghanistan, Central African Republic, Myanmar, Somalia, Sudan, Yemen, and Zimbabwe).
- Russia and China, the second and fourth biggest arms exporters, also export to climate—vulnerable countries and are known for ignoring international arms embargoes. Between 2013 and 2021, China has exported to 21 and Russia to 13 of the world’s most climate-vulnerable countries.

These arms exports not only divert money that is needed to instead mitigate and adapt to climate change, but also run the risk of fueling conflicts, repression, and human rights abuses for populations on the frontlines of climate change. This is a form of climate maladaptation.

Egypt is one of the many countries supported with arms deals rather than climate action

Egypt will host the UN climate talks, COP27, in November 2022, but it is much better known for its military spending than for its climate action.

- Between 2017 and 2021, Egypt has been one of the top five arms-importing countries, receiving 5.7% of global imports. Its main suppliers are Russia (41%), France (21%) and Italy (15%). It also receives support for its police and border guards from EU member states, particularly Germany.
- Yet Egypt has entered into deals for fossil fuels worth \$74bn since 2014, including with US companies like ExxonMobil and Chevron, has failed to develop effective climate adaptation plans, and is actively repressing climate and democracy activists in the country, including in the run-up to COP27.

Military spending could pay for a global Green New Deal

The richest countries have consistently failed to meet their promises to provide an insufficient \$100bn a year in climate finance to the world’s most climate-vulnerable countries. And they refuse to make any concrete commitments to pay for mounting loss and damage, such as the floods in Pakistan and the drought in the Horn of Africa in 2022.

- One year’s military spending by the top 10 military spenders would pay for promised international climate finance for 15 years (at \$100bn a year).
- \$70bn of climate adaptation could be paid with just 4% of what the top 10 (USA, China, India, UK, Russia, France, Germany, Saudi Arabia, Japan and South Korea) spend annually on the military (a ratio of 1:23) and 3% of annual global military spending (1:30).
- Together with other proposals for financing—such as an end of fossil-fuel subsidies, disbursement of Special Drawing Rights (SDRs), new taxes on fossil-fuel extraction, financial transactions, aviation and shipping—there is more than enough money to fund mitigation, adaptation, and loss and damage.

Faced with the climate crisis and the signs of reaching dangerous planetary tipping points, there is an overriding imperative to prioritise climate action and international cooperation to protect those who will be most affected. Yet in 2022, an arms race is exacerbating the climate crisis and preventing its resolution. It could not come at a worse time. To tackle the biggest threat to human security, the climate emergency, we need all countries—NATO members as well as Permanent UN Security Council members Russia and China—to work together to prioritise climate over militarism. There is no secure nation without a climate-secure planet.

This is the executive summary of a report published in November 2022 by Transnational Institute www.tni.org. Subscribe to their newsletter at www.tni.org/en/subscribe.

Mike Davis on becoming a Marxist

MIKE DAVIS

Editors' Note: We were saddened by news that Mike Davis passed away on October 25, 2022. Mike was a writer, activist, urban theorist, historian, and author of a number of books. This is an excerpt from the Preface to his Old Gods, New Enigmas: Marx's Lost Theory.

Read Marx!

Lee Gregovich's injunction has been rattling around my brain for more than half a century. A good friend of my dad, he was, I suppose, my "red godfather." His family, like many others from the Dalmatian coast, had emigrated to the copper mines of the American Southwest before the First World War. There they were embroiled in epic labor conflicts. Lee told rousing stories about his days as an IWW paper boy, selling the *Industrial Worker* in saloons and cathouses, and then watching as his father and 1,300 other striking miners, mostly Mexican and south Slav, were arrested by Phelps-Dodge vigilantes, put in manure-floored cattle cars, and "deported" to a bleak stretch of desert in New Mexico. In the 1930s he became active in the Cooks Union in San Diego and joined the Communist Party. The House Committee on Un-American Activities brought its inquisition to San Diego in 1954 and Lee was subpoenaed and then blacklisted by employers. He finally found a job cooking at the Chicken Shack, an old-style roadhouse near the picturesque mountain town of Julian.

When my father had a catastrophic heart attack in my junior year, I quit high school for a semester to drive a delivery truck for my uncle's wholesale meat company. The Chicken Shack was our most distant customer and once every week or so, after delivering to country restaurants with names like the Lariat and the Lazy J, I'd scuttle up the long road to Julian. On such days Lee and I had a ritual. After the order had been put in the walk-in, he'd pour me a small glass of red wine, we'd talk briefly about my dad's health or the Civil Rights movement (he was proud that I had become active in San Diego CORE), then, as I got up to leave, he'd slap me on the back and say, "Read Marx!" (I've always liked telling this story and was not surprised when a garbled version of it, insinuating that Lee was a mysterious Soviet agent, appeared in my FBI file.)

Lee himself, like millions of other rank-and-file socialists and communists, had read little or no Marx. *Wage, Labor and Capital*, perhaps, and certainly some Lenin, whose *The Teachings of Karl Marx* was a popular substitute for reading the old man himself. Most ordinary readers, however, cowered in face of that Everest of theory, Capital. The few who attempted it usually fell into one of the early crevasses of the first chapter and never returned for a second try. This only added, of course, to the mystique of Marx's genius and the prestige of party intellectuals who claimed to have reached the summit. A study of workers' libraries in Wilhelmine Germany found that

serious proletarian readers were especially interested in Darwinism and materialist interpretations of natural history, not the critique of political economy. Kautsky's *Economic Doctrines of Karl Marx* was "more borrowed than actually read."¹ In 1936, the Menshevik authors of *Karl Marx: Man and Fighter*—a biography that admirably focused on the thinker as revolutionist—estimated that "perhaps one socialist in a thousand has ever read any of Marx's economic writings, and of a thousand anti-Marxists not even one."²

Little had changed when I joined the Southern California Communist Party in 1968 in solidarity with their stand against the Russian suppression of the Prague Spring. I was flabbergasted that new members' political education consisted solely of reading Julius Fucik's *Notes from the Gallows*—the stirring last testament of a young Czech Communist executed in 1943, but hardly an introduction to Marxism. My own knowledge was limited to the *Paris Notebooks* and bits of *The German Ideology*, recommended in a popular book that I had read on Marx and alienation. The only member of the L.A. Party, young or old, who seemed to have a serious understanding of Marx, and indeed was reading the *Werke* in German, was newly recruited Angela Davis, and she was fighting too many important battles to have time to tutor the rest of us.

What made Marx a stranger to Marxist movements, however, was not simply the difficulty of certain key works and passages, but a series of other obstacles. Where to begin, for example? If you began at the beginning with dialectics, you had to endure Hegel scowling at you while you became increasingly befuddled—at least, that was my experience while trying to digest Marcuse's *Reason and Revolution* during lunch and supper breaks at work. I was delighted years later to discover an epigram in which the young Marx registered his own frustration with the Master and his interpreters:

"On Hegel"

Words I teach all mixed up into a devilish muddle,
Anyone may think just what he chooses to think;
Each may for himself suck wisdom's nourishing nectar;
Now you know all, since I've said plenty of nothing to you!³

If you gave G. W. F. a detour, you might discover, with the aid of interpretations by the Marxist Humanists then in vogue, the inspiring Marx of the Paris and Brussels years. (*The Holy Family* [1845], however, never made my reading list since the only person that I've ever known who read it was on acid at the time.) But then, once you thought that you had learned to walk, Althusser came along and the Young Marx suddenly became the Wrong Marx.

With few exceptions, however, the Marx of the Rue Elm and other seminars was disembodied from the "man and fighter." The works most infused with the passion of the barricades, the extraordinary political analyses of the 1848–50 cycle, were usually ignored by the philosophers. In my unsuccessful autodidact years, Marx seemed either emulsified in incompatible doctrines imposed by party ideologists (Diamat, for instance) or hidden away in mysterious untranslated manuscripts. In addition, it was almost impossible to gain an overview of the oeuvre since the publication of

the English version of the collected works was still years in the future. Martin Nicolaus's translation of the legendary *Grundrisse* in 1973—a milestone of the New Left Review/Penguin Books collaboration—considerably leveled the playing field for non-German readers, but it also added 900 pages of required study to the several thousand pages of the four volumes of *Capital*.

That same year, after losing a coveted niche in the trucking industry, I started UCLA as an adult freshman, attracted by rumors of a high-powered seminar on Capital led by Bob Brenner in the History Department. Brenner and his gang (Richard Smith, Jan Breidenbach, Maria Ramos, and others) were reading Capital in the context of debates within British Marxism on agrarian class struggles and the transition from feudalism to capitalism. Later the seminar moved on to crisis theory and twentieth-century economic history. It was an exhilarating experience and gave me the intellectual confidence to pursue my own agenda of eclectic interests in political economy, labor history, and urban ecology. Apart from Hal Draper's *Karl Marx's Theory of Revolution* and Michael Löwy's *The Theory of Revolution in the Young Marx*, both indispensable, I lost interest in Marx studies as it turned from the modes-of-production debate to intensely microscopic battles over the value form, the transformation problem, and the role of Hegelian logic in *Capital*. "Theory" in general, as it became disconnected from real-life battles and big historical questions alike, seemed to take a monstrously obscurantist turn toward the end of the century. I could never imagine Lee Gregovich imploring anyone to "read Jameson, read Derrida," much less to wade through the morass of Empire.

Surfing the Collected Works

Over the years my Marxism became rusty, to say the least. But there comes a time when every old student must decide whether or not to renew their driver's license. And reading Daniel Bensaid's *Marx for Our Times*, a spectacularly imaginative reinterpretation that breaks free of talmudic chains, whetted my appetite for a fresh look at the "non-linear Marx" that Bensaid proposes.⁴ Retirement from teaching, then a long illness finally gave me the leisure to browse through the Collected Works of Marx and Engels now in English and, in a pirated version, available for free online.⁵ Amongst recent writers who have made brilliant use of the Collected Works are John Bellamy Foster, the editor of *Monthly Review*, who has carefully reconstructed Marx's powerful ecological critique of capitalism—a new and exciting topic, particularly in light of later socialism's fetishism of large-scale agriculture; and Erica Benner, whose invaluable recovery of Marx's usually misrepresented views on nationalism is discussed in Chapter 2 ("Marx's Lost Theory"). And the mother lode has hardly been mined out: for example, Marx and Engels's hundreds of pages of acerbic commentaries on the deep games of nineteenth-century European politics, especially the geopolitical chess match between the British and Russian empires, clearly warrant a major new interpretation. Likewise, it would be illuminating to compare his theoretical writings on political economy with his concrete analyses of contemporary economic crises such as 1857 and 1866, topics usually assigned to the footnotes. More generally, I suspect, "Marx on the conjuncture" should become the new slogan of Marxologists.

The panoramic view of the oeuvre now available also makes it easier to recognize the blind spots and misdirections in the collaboration of Marx and Engels. The former, for instance, never wrote a single word about cities, and his passionate interests in ethnography, geology, and mathematics were never matched by a comparable concern with geography (later the forte of anarchists such as Élisée Reclus and Peter Kropotkin). He was relatively untraveled, and only at the very end of his life, desperately sick and seeking the sun, did he venture outside Western Europe. His letters from Algiers, praising the culture and dignity of the Arabs, indicated his capacity to transcend Eurocentric categories and revel in the newness of other worlds. (Alas, if only he hadn't been so wracked by illness and family tragedy.) The United States was another paradox. Its protean future was often on his mind—he was after all a correspondent for the *New York Tribune*—and he and Engels worked mightily to win support for Lincoln and Emancipation within the British labor movement. Yet, despite having read Tocqueville, he never focused on the unique features of its political system, especially the impact of early white-male suffrage on the development of its labor movement.

There can be no question that Marx saw far beyond the horizon of his century and that Capital, as the Economist (which Marx read faithfully) pointed out a few years back, remains startlingly contemporary even in the age of Walmart and Google. But in other cases Marx's vision was limited by the anomalous character of his chronological niche: arguably the most peaceful period of European history in a thousand years. Colonial interventions aside, liberal London-centered capitalism did not seem structurally to require large-scale inter-state warfare as a condition of its reproduction or as the inevitable result of its contradictions. He died, of course, before the new imperialism of the late 1880s and 1890s led to zero-sum conflicts amongst the major powers for shares of the world market. Nor could Marx, even after the massacre of the Communards, have possibly foreseen the horrific price that counter-revolution in the next century, including Thermidorean Stalinism, would exact from rank-and-file anarchists, socialists, and communists: at least 7–8 million dead.⁶ Since the youngest and most politically conscious tended always to be in the front lines, these repeated decimations of the vanguard entailed incalculable consequences—ones that have been almost entirely ignored by historians.

Likewise, all signs in Marx's day pointed to the continued erosion of belief and the secularization of industrial society. After the early writings, religion was quite understandably not a topic on his agenda. By the end of the century, however, the trends reversed, and political Catholicism, along a spectrum from embryonic Christian Democracy to the Zentrum to fascism, became the main competitor with socialism/communism in much of Europe, and the major obstacle to left electoral majorities in the 1910s–20s and 1950s–70s. This surprising Catholic resurgence, almost a second counter-reformation, owed much to the spread of Mariolatry and the church's aggressive appeal to proletarian mothers. The patriarchal character of the workers' movement, which Marx and Engels never challenged, made it blind to the forces at work. Despite a household full of strong, radical women, including three daughters who became prominent revolutionists in their own right, Marx never wavered as pater familias, and the movements built in his name, as Barbara Taylor and others

have pointed out, actually registered a retrogression from the striking feminism of many utopian socialist sects.⁷ Indeed, between Flora Tristan and Clara Zetkin, no woman was able to claim leadership in any of the major labor or socialist formations.

The point, even if initially difficult to swallow, is that socialists, if incomparably armored by Marx's critique of capitalism, also have something to learn from the critique of Marx and his Victorian extrapolations. I say "critique of Marx" rather than "critics of Marx" since, even in the case of those who were noble revolutionary figures in their own right, such as Bakunin and Kropotkin, the mischaracterizations of Marx's ideas were quite fantastic (as were his calumnies against them). The cult of Marx, preceded in the German workers' movement by the cult of Lassalle, justly honored a life of almost sacrificial dedication to human liberation, but otherwise did what all cults do—it petrified his living thoughts and critical method. He, of course, was aware of this danger, which is why he famously said of Jules Guesde and his "orthodox Marxist" wing of the French Workers Party: "*Ce qu'il y a de certain c'est que moi, je ne suis pas marxiste*" ("What is certain is that [if they are Marxists] I myself am not a Marxist"). How many more times would he have had to say that in the twentieth century?

Endnotes

1 Hans-Josef Steinberg and Nicholas Jacobs, "Workers' Libraries in Germany before 1914," History Workshop 1 (Spring 1976), pp. 175–6.

2 Hans-Josef Steinberg and Nicholas Jacobs, "Workers' Libraries in Germany before 1914," History Workshop 1 (Spring 1976), pp. 175–6.

Isaac Deutscher used to tell a story about his difficulties as a young Communist in finding an entryway into Capital. "I was relieved to hear that Ignacy Daszynski, our famous member of parliament, a pioneer of socialism, an orator on whose lips hung the parliaments of Vienna and Warsaw, admitted that he too found Das Kapital too hard a nut. 'I have not read it,' he boasted, 'but Karl Kautsky has read it and has written a popular summary of it. I have not read Kautsky either; but Kelles-Krauz, our party theorist, has read him, and he summarized Kautsky's book. I have not read Kelles-Krauz either, but that clever Jew, Herman Diamond, our financial expert, has read Kelles-Krauz, and has told me all about it.'" Isaac Deutscher, "Discovering Das Kapital," in Marxism in Our Time (San Francisco: Ramparts, 1971), p. 257.

3 Boris Nicolaievsky and Otto Maenchen-Helfen, Karl Marx: Man and Fighter, expanded edn (London: Allen Lane, 1973 [1933]), p. ix.

4 Daniel Bensaid, Marx for Our Times: Adventures and Misadventures of a Critique (London: Verso, 2002).

5 The collected works, of course, are not the complete works. The Marx/Engels archives, two-thirds in Amsterdam and one-third in Moscow, contain, in addition to published works, a vast collection of drafts (there are four of Capital), articles, newspaper columns, manifestos, fragments, 200 excerpt notebooks, and correspondence with 2,000 individuals. Publication of the whole has been variously estimated to require 130 to 180 printed volumes.)

6 This guesstimate is calculated on the following basis: Russian civil war — 1 million Red Army soldiers killed; repression in interwar Europe, including Italy and Spain — 150,000; China to 1949 — 1.5 million; Soviet Union, 1937 purge — 150,000 communists; Soviet Union, Second World War (party members and Komsomol only) — 3 million; Nazi Europe, including partisans — 500,000; Southeast Asia (Indochina, Philippines, Indonesia) — 1 million; and Latin America — 100,000.

7 Barbara Taylor, Eve and the New Jerusalem: Socialism and Feminism in the Nineteenth Century (London: Virago, 1983).

Who Would Kill the Gander that Goosed a Golden Egg?

DON FITZ

The suffering of US women under the iron heel of abortion is intensifying, especially for women of color. This makes it imperative to closely examine possible routes forward. As a teenager during the 1960s I witnessed two political paths that remain imprinted on my mind.

LBJ and 14 (b)

Even before classes began in 1963, I had organized the first high school Young Democrats chapter in Texas. By 1964 Houston Young Democrats were attending rallies for presidential candidate Lyndon B. Johnson, carrying signs reading "All the Way with LBJ—Repeal 14 (b)."

During the height of union activity several decades earlier, congress had passed the National Labor Relations Act (NLRA, 1935) which guaranteed private sector workers the right to form unions. During the beginning of the Cold War and strike waves of 1945 and 1946, congressional Republicans (with the aid of multiple Democrats) passed the Labor Management Relations Act (1947). It placed limitations on union activity, most importantly Section 14 (b). The odious 14 (b) allowed states to pass "Right to Work" laws which prohibited unions from requiring dues as a condition of employment. Workers could benefit from union activity without paying dues, thereby seriously undermining unions.

"Repeal 14 (b)" became the rallying cry. Unions told members "Vote for Democrats." Despite LBJ's winning the presidency and having Democratic Party (DP) control of the senate and house, 14 (b) was not repealed. Nor was it repealed during several subsequent administrations having a DP president and majority in both houses of congress.

Unlike gatherings of 1964, today 14 (b) is so ancient that if you ask high school students what they think about it, you will get blank stares. DP power brokers have successfully dumped repeal of 14 (b) into the dustbin of history.

A Most Reactionary President

Four years and a presidential election later Republican Richard Nixon was swept into office and was re-elected in 1972. Carrying 49 of 50 states, Nixon's re-election was one of the largest landslides in US history and showed overwhelming support for war against the Vietnamese people. Despite endorsement of his right wing agenda, more progressive actions occurred during Nixon's reign (1969-1974) than during any presidency since (including those of Dems): end to the Viet Nam War, start of the Food Stamp program, decriminalization of abortion, recognition of China, creation of Environmental Protection Agency, passage of Freedom of Information Act, formal dismantling of FBI's COINTEL program, creation of Earned Income Tax Credits, formal ban on biological weapons, and passage of the Clean Water Act.

When I recount this to my good DP friends, the response is something like "You can't credit that to Tricky Dick—he was forced to give in to the tremendous upheavals of his time."

Bingo! That is exactly the point. Nixon had to act as he did due to enormous social pressure. During a 10-year period, a generation of progressives had been exposed to two fundamental truths:

1. Electing a DP president with DP control of the senate and house can be accompanied by a failure to attain vitally important goals that people want, need, and were promised; and,
2. Mass movements with large scale disruptions can win progressive victories during the lordship of a vile president who despises each of those goals.

Logic of the Goose

In the 2022 elections, the Dems won a majority of the Senate but lost the House. This means that they would have a very hard time passing the Women's Health Protection Act or a constitutional amendment guaranteeing the right to an abortion. But the Senate could expand the number of Supreme Court justices, something that it shows zero interest in doing as of Christmas, 2022.

However, doing this would mean that abortion would cease to be a major issue in the 2024 election and make the re-election of Joe Biden virtually impossible. Winning in 2024 is vastly more important to the Dems than a setback in 2022.

As the Washington Post noted, the DP has finally found an issue that might help them at the ballot box. But securing abortion rights in 2022 would remove it from the 2024 agenda. Abortion rights are the Dems' golden egg, and they are not about to hatchet Mother Goose.

The task of DP politicians is **not** to bring better lives to people—it is to get elected. If promises to improve peoples' lives were kept, then the ability to make the promise evaporates. The true role of DP is to promise without delivering, while somehow getting people to believe the promise.

Each election cycle Dems scrounge around for a golden egg so they can chant their eternal refrain "Vote to get goosed or the Republicans will win!" Dems yearn to have their cake and eat it too. They must dangle abortion rights in front of voters' eyes—not actually win abortion rights.

Historical Reality of the Goose

As every psychologist should know, the best predictor of future behavior is past behavior. So, in addition to the Logic of the Goose, the history of the Dems regarding abortion helps chart their course.

During the last 50 years the Democrats could have written Roe vs Wade into law during the administrations of Jimmy Carter, Bill Clinton or Barack Obama; but never did so. As a US Senator, Joe Biden helped Clarence Thomas get on the US Supreme Court via his attacks on Anita Hill.

When Hillary Clinton ran for president, she chose anti-choice senator Tim Kaine as a running mate and said she was "ambivalent" about abortion. Obama botched opportunities to replace Justices Antonin Scalia and Ruth Bader Ginsburg on the supreme court.

This is what Margaret Kimberley of Black Agenda Report wrote about him: "During his 2008 presidential campaign Obama promised to pass and sign the Freedom of Choice Act, which would have enshrined abortion rights into law, and remove it from the purview of the courts. But he did no such thing. On April 29, 2009, he

gave a press conference on his 100th day in office and said, 'The Freedom of Choice Act is not my highest legislative priority.' Obama had majorities in both houses of Congress and a veto-proof majority in the Senate. Not only was this legislation not his highest priority, it wasn't a priority at all. He never attempted to get it passed."

While the US waited for the supreme court diktat overturning Roe v. Wade, Molly Shah expressed irritation that "there is currently no cohesive national campaign from either the Democratic party or large reproductive rights organizations to fight back." DP house leaders, including Speaker Nancy Pelosi, supported re-election of anti-choice Texas rep Henry Cuellar over an abortion rights challenger.

Cruel and Unusual Punishment

Stories of the plight of American women began showing up within weeks of the court decision:

"A Texas woman's water breaks at 18 weeks, leaving the fetus's chance of survival "as close to zero as you'll ever get in medicine." Yet she must wait until she is hemorrhaging profusely and burning with fever—that is, not dead but almost—before the doctors agree that it's legal to perform an abortion."

"A Wisconsinite bleeds for more than 10 days from an incomplete miscarriage because the emergency room staff fears that performing the standard-of-care uterine evacuation will be against the law."

Ohio minors who became pregnant as a result of rape had to leave the state for care.

Ohio women could neither legally end their pregnancies nor safely receive cancer treatment due to their pregnancies.

Fetal health issues render some pregnancies non-viable, yet laws prevent abortions.

Women whose "debilitating vomiting" that affects "their health, their ability to go to work or school, or their ability to care for their children" are unable to get needed abortions.

Patients threaten to commit suicide including one who said she would "attempt to terminate her pregnancy by drinking bleach."

Abortion should be the treatment for about 2% of pregnancies which are ectopic (the fertilized egg has implanted outside the uterus, endangering the patient).

Since the 8th amendment to the US constitution prohibits "cruel and unusual punishment," (which is "unacceptable due to the suffering, pain, or humiliation it inflicts on the person") it is not exactly clear why it fails to apply to those whose only crime is becoming pregnant.

Abortion bans have even more severe consequences for those who commit the crime of "being-pregnant-while-Black."

- "Black women are three times more likely to die from childbirth-related causes than white women."
- In Louisiana, 65% of abortions are performed on Black women.
- Black women comprise 12.8% of US women, but account for 22.3% of those living in poverty, which is a major cause of maternal death.

- Many patients cannot travel out of state for an abortion “due the cost of travel, child care responsibilities, and difficulty getting time off of work, just to name a few.”
- Knowing that women of color are three times as likely to be criminally charged with abortion, it is reasonable to ask ...
- Will white judges be more likely to conclude that women of color are less competent than white women to determine if they should have an abortion?
- Will women of color receive longer sentences for abortion (like what happens with marijuana and cocaine cases)?
- Will some medical staff be more likely to overlook pregnancy dangers in women of color?

Abortion rights have a unique significance for Black women. During slavery, masters offered bounties for hunters who returned escapees to the plantation. Today’s more repressive states reinvent this tradition by offering bounties to anyone who squeals on those associated with an abortion.

... as if They Depend on It

At this critical time, it is necessary to defend abortion rights as if women’s lives depend on it. Because they really do.

More and more are realizing that rights have been won by disruptive actions rather than joining cheer-leading squads for unreliable politicians. Rather than being benevolently handed down to women, abortion rights were won “through mass demonstrations, teach-ins, takeovers and sit-ins.” Judith McDaniel recalls disruptive actions such as ...

- Suffragists chaining themselves to the White House fence.
- ACT UP protesters chaining themselves to the desks of pharmacy executives.
- African American students in the South sitting at lunch counters.

Reviewing multiple social reforms, Paul Street concludes that “None of these things were won simply by voting and/or Supreme Court benevolence alone. They were more fundamentally won through mass popular resistance and disruption: strikes, marches, sit-ins, sit-downs, occupations, work stoppages, movements, and movement cultures beneath and beyond the big money major party time-staggered big media candidate-centered electoral extravaganzas that are sold to us as ‘politics.’”

A funny thing happened when fact-checking for 14 (b). When I googled “Repeal of Taft Hartley Section 14(b)” the first link that came up was this very solid resolution by the American Federation of Teachers. Scrolling to the bottom revealed this date: 1965. Think about that—1965. The date suggests that within two years of electing LBJ and his DP gaggle in both houses of congress, the union movement had backed down from insisting that 14 (b) be repealed. Oh yes, there are routinized statements now and again calling for its repeal, but nothing approaching a thunderous call for its repeal as a condition for unions to continue to support the DP.

With the watchdog snoring, the Dems back-stepped to a state-by-state defense against Right-to-Work legislation. Does this foretell an “abortion-rights-in-some-states-only” strategy for today? The DP seems to have given up on (or never initiated) a mass mobilization for increasing the number of supreme court justices, or a law

guaranteeing abortion rights throughout the nation, or (too controversial to even consider) a constitutional amendment for protecting women’s lives.

Though making a lot of racket at election time, post-election Dems will move to a cooling off period so women can adjust themselves to losing a basic right. But the iron is hot and this is no time to cool off. Not six weeks after the court’s Day of Infamy, Kansas voters resoundingly defeated an anti-abortion amendment to their constitution. Between 2010 and the 2022 court decision, the number of Americans saying all abortions should be banned fell from 15% to 8%. During the same period, those agreeing that abortion should be legal in all cases climbed from 18% to 33%.

Vermont residents will consider the Reproductive Liberty Amendment, stating: “that an individual’s right to personal reproductive autonomy is central to the liberty and dignity to determine one’s own life course and shall not be denied or infringed unless justified by a compelling State interest achieved by the least restrictive means.”

Missouri’s residents also enjoy the right to amend the state constitution. It elects right wing politicians yet simultaneously passes progressive legislation. Missouri voters have repeatedly rejected Right to Work legislation and have approved shutting down puppy mills. Missouri voters gave the nod to medical marijuana and approved Medicaid expansion. This means that 5-20% of Missourians vote for progressive agendas while not voting for Democratic Party politicians.

(If you are registered to vote in Missouri and would help gather signatures for an abortion rights amendment to the state constitution, email secretary@missourigreen-party.org or call 314-727-8554.)

The current struggle for abortion rights reminds us of the immense efforts for women’s suffrage, which was a roller-coaster battle requiring ongoing civil disobedience. Soon after the creation of the US, women lost the right to vote in New York (1777), Massachusetts (1780), New Hampshire (1784) and all other states except New Jersey (1787), which revoked the right in 1807.

Women’s right to vote was first gained in Wyoming Territory (1869). Women lost the right to vote in Utah (1887) but regained it in 1896. Women’s suffrage won in Washington state (1910), California, (1911), Oregon (1912), Arizona (1912), Kansas (1912), Alaska territory (1913), New York (1917), South Dakota (1917), and Oklahoma (1917). Women won partial suffrage in Illinois (1913), North Dakota (1917), Indiana (1917), Nebraska (1917), and Michigan (1917). The 19th amendment (guaranteeing women’s suffrage throughout the US) was passed by Congress in 1919 and ratified on August 18, 1920.

Two lessons stand out: rights which are taken away can provoke intense struggles to regain them; and rights can be won at the state level as a critical step toward winning them at the national level. Working for a state constitutional amendment guaranteeing abortion rights can be a double-edged sword. The dull blunt edge can drag the movement into an abyss (like Right to Work) where it will be stuck for eternity if it abandons the goal of a national victory. The sharp edge cuts through the Gordian Knot as it walks the suffragette path of mass civil disobedience.

Don Fitz (fitzdon@aol.com) is on the Editorial Board of Green Social Thought, where a version of this article originally appeared. He was the 2016 candidate of the Missouri Green Party for Governor. He is author of Cuban Health Care: The Ongoing Revolution (2020).

Forever Young: Staughton Lynd

ANDY PIASCIK

Suddenly Staughton Lynd is all the rage. Again. In the last several years, Lynd has published a number of new books as well as new editions of classics such as *Rank and File*, plus a memoir co-authored with his wife Alice. In addition, two books about his life as an activist have been published, one on the years through 1970 by educator Carl Mirra (*The Admirable Radical: Staughton Lynd and Cold War Dissent, 1945-1970*) and another about his work since 1970 by historians Mark Weber and Stephen Paschen, *Side by Side: Alice and Staughton Lynd, the Ohio Years*.

In an epoch of imperial hubris and corporate class warfare on steroids, a Lynd revival could hardly have come at a better time. Soldier, coal miner, Sixties veteran, recent college graduate—there's much to be gained by all from a study of Lynd's life and work. In so doing, it's inspiring to discover how frequently he was in the right place at the right time and, more importantly, on the right side.

Mississippi

During the tumultuous summer of 1964, Lynd was invited to coordinate the Freedom Schools established in Mississippi by the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee (SNCC). The schools were an integral part of the Herculean effort to end apartheid in the United States and became models for alternative schools everywhere. That August, Lynd supported the Mississippi Freedom Democratic Party (MFDP) at the Democratic Party convention. Led by Fannie Lou Hamer and Bob Moses, the MFDP had earned the right to represent their state with their blood and their extraordinary courage. Instead, the party hierarchy supported the official, illegal delegation, a pathetic band of reactionaries who - the irony is too delicious - supported not the candidate of their own party Lyndon Johnson but his opponent and their ostensible enemy, Republican Barry Goldwater, for president. This backstabbing was carried out by liberal icons Hubert Humphrey, Walter Reuther and Walter Mondale and endorsed, alas, by Reverend Martin Luther King.

Vietnam

In early 1965, Lynd spoke at Carnegie Hall in one of the first events organized in opposition to the U.S. invasion of Vietnam. A short time later, Students for a Democratic Society (SDS) asked him to chair the first national demonstration against the war, where he was again a keynote speaker. That April 17, a crowd of 25,000 that was five times larger than even the most optimistic organizers had anticipated turned out



Photo by Ben Gilbert, September 1968.

in Washington, and what would become the largest anti-war movement in US history was born.

That summer, Lynd helped organize the Assembly of Unrepresented People in Washington. Timed to coincide with the 20th anniversary of the murder of tens of thousands of civilians in Hiroshima and Nagasaki, the gathering also included a rally at the White House where peace with the people of Vietnam was declared. Lynd has recalled the bemusement with which the relatively small band of demonstrators was received by those charged with protecting the government from its people. In reply, he told a military police officer that they were the first of what would eventually be millions, a statement that sooner than anyone could imagine proved prophetic. By 1967, a majority of people in the U.S. had declared peace with Vietnam.

Movement Contributions

Lynd would continue as one of the seminal figures of the 1960's. He was both a tireless organizer and the author of numerous articles in important movement publications like *Liberation*, *Radical America*, the *Guardian*, and *Studies on the Left*. With Michael Ferber, he documented the movement against the military draft in *The Resistance*, one of the best books about Sixties organizing.

Lynd was an enthusiastic supporter of the New Left and embraced precepts like participatory democracy and decentralization. Ex-radicals of his generation like Irving Howe, Bayard Rustin and Michael Harrington, by contrast, spent much of the Sixties attacking SNCC and SDS. He spoke for many when he mocked their enthusiasm for Johnson and the Democrats as "coalition with the Marines."

This, too, proved uncannily prophetic. Within a year of being elected in 1964, Johnson 1.) ordered a massive escalation in Vietnam; 2.) sent an invasion force to the Dominican Republic to support military thugs who had overthrown a democratically elected government; and 3.) armed and funded an incredibly violent coup in Indonesia in which over a million people were killed. The Peace Candidate indeed.

Blacklisted From Academia and Beyond

At the end of 1965, Lynd made a fateful trip to Hanoi where he witnessed the carnage inflicted by US bombers. Up to that point, he was one of the most promising new scholars in the country. Upon his return, however, his career in academia was essentially at an end. A tenure track position at Yale suddenly disappeared. Department heads at other universities enthusiastically offered teaching positions, only to be overruled by higher-ups.

Lynd never looked back. He became an accomplished scholar outside the academy and one of the most perceptive and prolific chroniclers of "history from below," with a special interest in working class organizing. From a series of interviews, he and Alice produced the groundbreaking book *Rank and File*, which begat the Academy Award-nominated documentary film *Union Maids*.

Youngstown

Lynd moved to Ohio in 1976, became an attorney and, when the mills in Youngstown began to close, assisted steelworkers in an unsuccessful attempt to take them over. In a book he wrote about the effort, *The Fight Against Shutdowns: Youngstown's Steel Mill Closings*, Lynd explored the biggest little secret of all, one

that people everywhere would do well to heed: We who do the work can build a better world, and we can best do it without the parasitic Super Rich who contribute nothing and weigh us down like a monstrous ball and chain.

Today

Lynd is eighty-six now. The step is slower, and his eyesight isn't the best. Ten years ago, he had open heart surgery—"an affair of the heart," he calls it. "My cardiac surgeon said I came as close to becoming permanently horizontal as one can come without actually doing so."

He talks of how deeply he misses dear friend Howard Zinn. He recalls driving through Mississippi late at night, hopelessly lost, just days after civil rights workers James Chaney, Andrew Goodman, and Mickey Schwerner had been abducted and murdered. He talks of his remarkable life's work with great humility and not at all wistfully, but in search of lessons it might hold, especially for the young. A teacher extraordinaire, he is guided by the principle that a teacher is also a student and all students teachers. And he writes and writes, as prolifically as ever, one book after another as well as articles and book reviews for *Z*, *Counterpunch*, the *Industrial Worker* and numerous other periodicals and websites.

Lynd has seen more than his share of colleagues come and go. Some flamed out after a brief period of frantic busyness; others moved on to different lives and nice-paying gigs. Still going strong, Lynd offers long-term commitment ("long distance running," as he calls it) and accompaniment—professionals living alongside workers and the unrepresented and contributing much-needed skills to the struggle for freedom, all the while walking side by side as equals - as alternatives. He also believes as passionately as ever that a better world is indeed possible.

Andy Piascik is a long-time activist and award-winning author who writes for The Independent, Counterpunch, Znet and many other websites and publications. His most recent book is the novel In Motion.

Staughton Lynd photo courtesy of University of Chicago Photographic Archive, apf 7-00301.

Capitalism, the Absurd System: A View from the United States

JOHN BELLAMY FOSTER & ROBERT W. MCCHESENEY

Originally published in Monthly Review, 2010, Volume 62, Issue 02 (June)

A few years ago, in a class one of us taught, a discussion arose about how capitalism works as a system in which the need for the few to maximize profit drives the entire political-economic structure.¹ The students appeared to grasp how the capital accumulation process has a strong effect, often negative, on the course of a society's development. The discussion then turned to Salvador Allende's Chile of the early 1970s, where the goal was to develop a socialist political economy. "Knowing what you do about how capitalism functions," the students were asked, "what would a socialist system look like?" They were unusually quiet. Finally, one of them blurted out: "I don't know how it *could* work. I guess the government would have to kill everybody."

The question of how a socialist society would operate raised a horrible, dystopian image in this student's mind. Such libertarian fears of a totalitarian state imposing socialism by force, even to the point of annihilation, on an unwilling people, who are presumed to be capitalist by nature, are all too common. This brings to mind Fredric Jameson's comment: "Someone once said that it is easier [for most people in today's society] to imagine the end of the world than to imagine the end of capitalism."²

Perhaps nothing points so clearly to the alienated nature of politics in the present day United States as the fact that capitalism, the economic system that drives the society, is effectively off-limits to critical review or discussion. To the extent that capitalism is mentioned by politicians or pundits, it is regarded in hushed tones of reverence for the genius of the market, its unquestioned efficiency, and its providential authority.

One might quibble with a corrupt and greedy CEO or a regrettable loss of jobs, but the superiority and necessity of capitalism—or, more likely, its euphemism, the so-called "free market system"—is simply beyond debate or even consideration. There are, of course, those who believe that the system needs more regulation and that there is room for all sorts of fine-tuning. Nevertheless, there is no questioning of the basics.

This prohibition on critically assessing capitalism begins in the economics departments and business schools of our universities where, with but a few exceptions, it is easier to find an advocate of the immediate colonization of Mars than it is to find a scholar engaged in genuine radical criticism of capitalism. This critical dearth extends to our news media, which have a documented track record of promoting the profit system, and a keen distaste for those that advocate radical change. It reaches all of us in one form or another. Anyone who wishes to participate in civic life quickly grasps that being tagged as anti-free market (or socialist) is a near-certain way to guarantee one's status as a political outcast. To criticize the system is to criticize the nation and "democracy."

This is a dream world for those atop the system. Such ideological dominance is worth more than a standing army of a million troops to those wishing to maintain their positions of power and privilege. But the illegitimacy of addressing the nature and logic of capitalism handcuffs almost everyone else. As long as serious treatment of capitalism, the dominant social system, remains off-limits, social science itself is deeply compromised.

The failure of a society so marked in myriad ways by capitalism to confront this central reality can only be seen as a great evasion. It is the refusal to engage in meaningful self-criticism, to seek self-knowledge. Americans are like the proverbial fish unaware of the water that surrounds and permeates their existence.

Of course, much of this lack of awareness of the central political-economic realities of today's society is a product of market mystification, which cloaks capitalist property relations, and which constitutes the system's primary advantage over all previous systems of social repression. In John Steinbeck's *The Grapes of Wrath*, an enraged Okie tenant farmer, a victim of the Dust Bowl and the Great Depression, wants to know, as he is being removed from his farm by the bank, whom he can shoot. The tractor driver who comes to demolish his house says it would do no good for the farmer to shoot him, since he's just an ordinary working stiff doing his job and would be quickly replaced by another. When the farmer counters that he will then shoot the person who gave the order, the tractor driver replies that this too would be useless, since that individual is simply a bank employee. "Well, there's a president of the bank," continues the farmer. "There's a board of directors. I'll fill up the magazine of the rifle and go into the bank."

The driver said, "Fellow was telling me the bank gets orders from the East. The orders were, 'Make the land show profit or we'll close up.'"

"But where does it stop? Who can we shoot? I don't aim to starve to death before I kill the man that's starving me."

"I don't know. Maybe there's nobody to shoot. Maybe the thing isn't men at all. Maybe, like you said, the property's doing it. Anyway I told you my orders."

"I got to figure," the tenant said. "We all got to figure. There's some way to stop this. It's not like lightning or earthquakes. We've got a bad thing made by men, and by God that's something we can change." The tenant sat in his doorway, and the driver thundered his engine and started off.... The iron guard rail bit into the house-corner, crumbled the wall, and wrenched the little house from its foundation so that it fell sideways crushed like a bug.... The tractor cut a straight line on, and the air and the ground vibrated with its thunder. The tenant man stared after it, his rifle in his hand. His wife was beside him, and the quiet children behind. And all of them stared after the tractor.³

The problem faced by Steinbeck's hapless tenant farmer is that there seems to be no individual or group of individuals who are ultimately responsible and accountable for the economic decisions that are harming people all over the country. It is a system

"made by men," and some are obviously gaining at the expense of others. The relation between the haves and the have-nots is clear, but the opacity of the market and the impersonality of it all nonetheless seem to constrain the possibility of active rebellion.⁴

This opacity of the capitalist system and of the relations of class and power that constitute it create the illusion of freedom, based on a seeming lack of direct coercion. Who really is the boss? Who is making the decisions? CEOs? Stockholders? Financial markets?

We come to believe that, as individuals, we are unconstrained in our day-to-day activities, since we remain at liberty, except when the state intrudes on our lives. Everything around us seems to function via Adam Smith's invisible hand. What we lose sight of is the reality of an alienated, commodified existence with its innumerable chains forged by class and property relations.

Behind the Veil of Money

The question we should ask is: What is society actually like when the veil of money is removed, and the real face of power is seen? Is society, stripped of its ideological cover and reduced to nakedness, one of equality—where four hundred individuals in the United States (the Forbes 400) own almost as much wealth as the bottom half of the population (150 million people)?⁵ Is this a rational society, when a trillion dollars each year is spent on the U.S. military?⁶ Can it be justified when the system, according to modern science, is pointing to mass extinction of the species, quite possibly humanity itself?

Capitalism's main economic claim to being an indispensable system is that it promotes economic growth, the benefits of which ostensibly trickle down to the vast majority. Today, however, in the mature capitalist economies, economic growth has slowed to a crawl (though sufficient to threaten the environment). The gains of labor productivity flow upwards by myriad pumps, after which they are seldom allowed to trickle down. The result is a deeply unequal society and generalized economic stagnation, associated with a dearth of effective demand—countered only in part by financial bubbles, which eventually burst with disastrous effects. In the past five decades, the U.S. economy has grown, but at slower and slower rates. The stagnation of the last ten years resembles nothing so much as the stagnation of the 1930s (i.e., the Great Depression years). (See Chart One). The same is true to varying extents for all the other rich, mature, capitalist economies.

This long-term slowdown is associated with growing structural inequality. The economic surplus generated by society is amassed more and more at the top. Worker productivity is much greater than it was back in 1975, but very little of this increased wealth actually goes to workers themselves. As Chart Two demonstrates, the wages of U.S. manufacturing workers have fallen rapidly during the last three and a half decades as a share of value added in U.S. manufacturing. The median wage of all nonagricultural workers has stagnated over the same period.

In this *Les Misérables* economy, it is hardly surprising that the general quality of life for most people has not improved—despite the continuing growth of overall social wealth and the increase in human productive capacities. The Happy Planet Index, developed by the New Economics Foundation, examines how "happy" a

country is—as measured by a combination of life expectancy and life satisfaction in relation to its ecological footprint. In the 2009 Happy Planet Index, the United States—the very model of mature capitalism—ranked a dismal 114 out of 143 included countries.⁷ The “greed is good,” “shop ‘til you drop,” “whoever dies with the most toys wins” ethos that marks free market capitalism is not conducive to genuine human happiness. What it generates in ever-increasing levels—even among its more successful strata—is stress, heart disease, loneliness, depression, and the waste of human potential. “This crippling of individuals I consider the worst evil of capitalism,” Albert Einstein wrote in “Why Socialism?” in volume 1, number 1 of *Monthly Review* (May 1949).

A lot of this damage to individuals has to do with our lack of concern for collective needs. The physical infrastructure of the United States—the built environment of our cities, roads, railroads, bridges, public water and electrical systems, parks, etc.—is crumbling. The per capita ecological footprint of the United States far exceeds what can be sustained at a global level, contributing to rapid degradation of the earth system. Public education throughout the country is in marked decline. Much of what we produce is nonessential, indeed waste, including wasted labor. The United States has fully lived up to John Kenneth Galbraith’s observation half a century ago that modern U.S. capitalism generates “private wealth” and “public squalor.”⁸

Massive amounts of labor and resources go toward lethal military purposes, while an increasing amount of human labor and productive capacity lies idle. By virtually all accounts, economic stagnation will be the order of the day for at least a decade, maybe decades, to come. In March 2010, *USA Today* asked legendary financier Warren Buffett, the second richest individual in the United States: “What if...the U.S. economy goes into a prolonged period of stagnation and weakness, creating a Japanese-like lost decade or two?” Buffett answered: “As long as it isn’t a century, I’m OK.”⁹

Young Americans are entering an economy in which they have little or no creative or meaningful role to play. It is far truer today than when Paul Goodman wrote his 1960 classic, *Growing Up Absurd*, that there are “fewer jobs that are necessary and unquestionably useful; that require energy and draw on some of one’s best capacities; and that can be done keeping one’s honor and dignity.” Today even the most wasteful, alienating, and degrading jobs are difficult to get, with growing unemployment, and even faster growing underemployment.¹⁰

We face the situation in the next generation of the continued development of tremendous labor-saving technologies, many that are revolutionary in impact. Yet, instead of leading to a higher quality of life for all or most people, these new productive technologies will be deployed primarily to maximize the profits of those atop the system. They will appear, in some respects, to be the enemy of the workers and communities they help to displace. Likewise, in the coming generation, large swaths of our countryside will likely be torn up and developed for tacky residential projects and gated communities, while a good part of our cities and inner-ring suburbs rot. All of this, we are told, is basically unavoidable, the price we pay for having the privilege of living in a free society.

No, it isn’t. It is the price we pay for living in a capitalist society. It is a system in which the “need” of the wealthy to make profit drives everything else, and it is increasingly leading to irrational and disastrous results.

The Plutocratic System

Boiled down, U.S. politics under today’s mature capitalism are not about the welfare of the *demos* (i.e., the people) as envisioned in classical notions of democracy, but rather about which party can best deliver profitability to investors and corporations. There are continuing debates between those who simply want to slash labor costs, taxes, and regulations for the rich, and those who want to do some of that but also use some regulation and government spending to encourage higher wages and demand-driven growth. Both sides, however, accept that making the economy profitable for the owning class is the *sine qua non* of successful administration. Within these constraints, there are occasional important political fights and periodic bones to throw to the electorate. But, in times of economic stagnation, the bones get smaller and even disappear. What passes for genuine political debate often tends to be irrelevant gibberish and blatant manipulation on side issues, or inconsequential nitpicking on minutiae. The big stuff is off the table. The system is democratic in theory, plutocratic (rule by the rich) in content.

The hollowness of democracy in today’s capitalism is evident in the blatant corruption of governance at all levels in the United States, and the non-accountability of all the major players. The corruption we are discussing is not about politicians getting inordinately great seats at the World Series, but the degeneration of the system and the dominance of a culture of greed that is now pervasive and institutionalized, contaminating all aspects of life. The manner in which, during the current Great Recession, the dominant institutions and investors were able to coalesce and demand hundreds of billions, even trillions, of dollars in public money as a blank check to the largest banks—and then shamelessly disperse multimillion-dollar bonuses to individuals at the apex of those very same corporations now on the public dole—was a striking reminder of the limits of self-government in our political economy. When the Masters of the Universe, as those atop the economic system have been called, need money, when they need bail-outs, when they need the full power of the state, there is no time for debate or inquiry or deliberation. There is no time for the setting of conditions. There is only time to give them exactly what they want. Or else! Egged on by the news media, all responsible people fall in line or face ostracism. As for education and the social services that mark the good society, well, they have to wait in line and hope something is left after the capitalist master is fed. In stagnant times, it is a long wait.

Marx’s work provides searing insights on how to understand a society that, at the surface, appears to be one thing but, at its deeper productive foundations, is something else. Marx argued that a core contradiction built into capitalism was between its ever-increasing socialization and enhancement of productivity, and its ongoing system of private appropriation of profit. In other words, one of the great virtues of capitalism, in comparison to the relatively stagnant societies that preceded it, is that it is constantly revolutionizing society’s productive capacity and the social interconnections between people within production. But, at a certain point, private control

over the economy comes into stark conflict with the vast productive capacities of social labor that have developed. These means of private control, the dominant class/property relations, become “so many fetters” on the further development of society, of human potential, of even the sustainability of human society. The fetters must therefore be “burst asunder,” to allow for new stages of human development.¹¹

The Renewal of Socialism

It seems clear that this need for a “bursting asunder” is where the United States is now. Capitalism, viewed as a system of generalized commodity production motivated by the competitive pursuit of private gain without limits, and thus driven to the amassing of concentrated wealth, even at the expense of public welfare and environmental sustainability, is well past its productive era—during which it could make claims to some degree of rationality. We have reached “The End of Rational Capitalism.”¹² It survives now on bubbles, bloated debt, military spending that borders on suicidal, and a deadening hypercommercialism.

When we state that capitalism is off-limits to critical review and analysis, what we really mean is that socialism, as the only rational successor to capitalism, is off-limits. If there is no credible alternative to capitalism, then there is no more reason to discuss transcending capitalism than there would be to debate the means of preventing lightning storms and earthquakes, as Steinbeck’s farmer observed. But in fact we are talking about relations and things made by human beings, and these can be changed, and have been changed enormously over the course of human history.

Since the dawn of class societies maybe five or six millennia ago, those in power have decried and demonized the ideas that threatened the status quo. Capitalism, as a specific form of class society, is no different. All prospective post-capitalist societies are denounced as so barbaric as to be beyond legitimate consideration.

No one today would say that socialism is inevitable. The odds indeed may be heavily stacked against it. But we can say that it is necessary if our species is to have much of a future. The old socialist slogan “Socialism or Barbarism” made famous by Rosa Luxemburg, although meaningful in its time, may need now to be replaced with “Socialism or Exterminism.”¹³ Barbarism, it appears, is no longer the greatest danger. Science tells us that, with a continuation of “business as usual,” extermination of humans as well as innumerable other species is the most probable result—and in an extremely short historical period. The absurd thing is that we can’t seem to alter business as usual, even under these dire conditions. Why? Because business as usual is capitalism, which has made the world prey to its own self-expansion. As Steinbeck wrote in *The Grapes of Wrath*: “The bank—the monster has to have profits all the time. It can’t wait. It’ll die....When the monster stops growing, it dies. It can’t stay one size.”¹⁴ All of this suggests that socialism, which offers the possibility of a more egalitarian, democratic, sustainable, and collective response to our problems, is a necessity on both social and environmental grounds if we expect to have a chance at a rational future—or indeed any long-term future at all.

What is socialism? We cannot offer anything like a complete account here (the story of socialism is a long one and is still in the making), but it begins with the idea that society’s resources should be directed to serving the needs of people, not the

profit dictates of the few. It is the socialization (democratization) of the economic sphere, and also the enlargement (de-privatization) of the political sphere. From that starting point, we are open-minded. There is a broad range of options, much to be debated, and enormous room for experimentation. There is a role for markets alongside democratic planning (for example, consumer markets), but not for a market society—that is, the Hayekian utopia of the self-regulating market, which becomes merely a disguise for the concentration of economic power and wealth.

The classical notion was that socialist movements would succeed, not in opposition to democracy, but as its champions. Among the contributions of the Soviet Union to our understanding of history is the confirmation of the fact that if socialism is not grounded in popular power, it in effect annihilates itself and capitalism is restored. Mere state ownership of key productive forces is not enough to create a socialist society; the people must exercise a sovereign rule over these productive forces and society as a whole, and the society must be organized to promote collective needs.¹⁵ Just as democracy is not an accomplished reality unless the vast majority of the people rule society, so socialism is not an accomplished reality unless the associated producers control the productive forms of society and use them rationally and sustainably in the collective interest. The two, in fact, require each other for their fulfillment.

With the failures and successes of some of the early socialist experiments in our rear-view mirrors, and the new socialism of the twenty-first century, pioneered above all in Latin America, in front of us, we believe that the classical notion of socialism has resumed its central role. This is a period of socialist renewal and revolutionary democracy. To us, it is encouraging to see the left victories across Latin America in the past decade. Their significance is made evident by the vitriol they have engendered in the mainstream and business press in the United States and Europe.

A key question thus arises: Has the moment for the renewal of U.S. socialism arrived?

Some of our friends would respond: “No. Socialism is permanently beyond our reach. The best we can hope for is the reform of capitalism along progressive lines.” They argue that capitalism can be made into a kinder and more rational system, increasingly in accord with the needs of humanity and the earth. Popular pressure, they say, can bring about enlightened government policies that will capture the benefits of capitalist economics and minimize the negative consequences. They make the case because they believe capitalism is so entrenched that it is impossible to do anything but seek reform—and they fear any hint of opposition to capitalism will marginalize them politically—or because they genuinely believe that capitalism can be tamed and made into a relatively benign and progressive society. The dream world from this perspective tends to be Scandinavian social democracy, in particular the Sweden of the Olof Palme era in the early and middle 1970s.

Sweden, during the decades of relative prosperity following the Second World War, was, in many ways, an enviable society. It enjoyed a degree of economic equality that has rarely been approached in a capitalist society, associated with high wages, superior social programs, and progressive taxation. It provided high-quality universal health care and free education up through university. The condition

of women—described by Marx, after Fourier, as the measure of all human progress—was much better in Sweden, in that period, than in most capitalist societies.¹⁶

To be sure, the Swedish model, when it was “viable,” was heavily dependent on Sweden’s stature within the imperial global order. Sweden was clearly a beneficiary of the imperialism of the North and West, and not innocently so, given its substantial military budget and arms sales in these years. It is well to remember that social democracy has never been even a remote possibility for today’s peripheral capitalist countries. It was exclusively open to the club at the center of the world system, i.e., those countries that have continually benefitted from a system of international plunder.

Sweden under Palme was not a socialist society, in our terms, but rather a corporatist, social democratic one, in which the impossible of impossibles seemed to occur for a short time under fortuitous circumstances: the irreconcilables of capital and labor were apparently reconciled.

Self-described Marxist friends have told us that, if they could push a button and move the United States to where Sweden was in the early 1970s, they would gladly forgo any hopes of transcending capitalism and creating a genuinely socialist economy. This attitude points to something of practical importance: on many matters of contemporary political organizing in the United States, the efforts of the explicitly socialist left converge with those of Keynesian left-liberals and social democrats. Together, both sides work for increased social spending, environmental sanity, equitable taxation, increased regulation, reductions in militarism, open governance, full employment, civil liberties, and workers’ rights. It is all about reducing the power of capital and increasing the power of everyone else. This is the common ground that defines the broader left in the United States, and that makes the Swedish model of the Palme era seem so attractive to many.

But the main lesson to be learned from the Sweden of left-liberal and social democratic dreams is not that capitalism can be reformed and therefore need not be fundamentally challenged. Instead, the main lesson is that those progressives who aspire to radical social reforms can only hope to have sufficient leverage to win these reforms if the threat of socialism is looming on the horizon. In Sweden’s case: the Soviet Union across the Baltic. The left can expect to achieve most in every respect when the threat it represents is one to be taken seriously.

The current and pathetically weak state of the progressive forces in the United States points to the dangers of political demobilization. On issue after issue, progressives tend to garner a significant percentage of the American people’s support, yet they do not have anything remotely close to commensurate political influence. The recent debacle over health care, in which the Obama administration and its Congressional allies successfully played the left-wing and voting base of the Democratic Party for patsies and delivered on a gold platter a bill to the liking of the corporate sector, is the most recent evidence. Of course part of the liberal-left’s weakness in U.S. politics is due to the news media, unfavorable election laws, and a number of other factors with which progressives are all too familiar. But a more significant reason for that weakness is that nobody in power fears the liberal-left—and no one should. The liberal-left tends to trip over itself as it establishes its pro-market *bona fides* for decision makers. “Take us seriously, pretty please; we are not really radicals and certainly not

socialists, we want to make your free market system work better, and don’t we have some jolly-good ideas,” they seem to say.

The only way to exact major reforms from those in power is to show them that we really mean it; to convey the message that if the real demands of the people, expressed in mass movements, are not met by the system (or are met only in very limited ways), then we as a body will make serious attempts to accomplish these ends by transcending the current system of power. Think of the great progressive reforms in modern U.S. history. The Wagner Act. Social Security. The Voting Rights Act. These came when those in power were petrified. They arose because of mass revolts from below, and because radicals recognized that it was the peculiar responsibility of the left to help mobilize the working class to fight for their own interests and their own needs—to take to the streets and fight power head on.

Consider why rulers in other nations, like France or Greece, tend to have greater difficulty implementing cutbacks in social programs during crises: Because, when they look out the window, they see a mass of people who would threaten the perpetuation of their system, if the vested interests were to engineer a class war from above in an attempt to turn back the clock. This makes the position of the capitalist class in such countries much more tenuous. The ability of the Swedish Social Democrats to win their tremendous reforms arose through the struggles of a working-class movement that was always populated with “extremist” elements open to expropriating private capital altogether.

From the birth of democracy in antiquity, it has been true that those with property will only concede fundamental rights to those without property when they fear for the very survival of their own privileges. “If there is no struggle,” as Frederick Douglass said in 1857, “there is no progress....Power concedes nothing without a demand. It never did and it never will....If we ever get free from the oppressions and wrongs heaped upon us, we must pay for their removal. We must do this by labor, by suffering, by sacrifice, and if needs be, by our lives and the lives of others.”¹⁷ People arrive at more radical, revolutionary positions through concrete struggle.

The unwillingness, so common among U.S. progressives, to embrace a critique of capitalism, to take it to its radical conclusions, including the necessity of a serious class struggle, has another unfortunate political consequence. It opens the door to phony right-wing populist movements seizing the mantle of “radical” opposition to the status quo. With the economic system off-limits to criticism (even invisible in its main power dimensions), attention necessarily gravitates to government as the root of all evil. The state must therefore be the *source* of the peoples’ problems; and indeed, it seems very seldom to operate in their real interests. It is the state, after all, that imposes taxes that seem to provide ordinary people few benefits; runs deficits, the burden of which falls disproportionately on those who gain the least; and controls the military and police. In today’s Tea Party ideology, engineered principally by the right, capital is deemed natural, while the state is unnatural—imposed from without on those who would otherwise be free. The social crisis is then seen as a crisis of too much government, too much interference by state interests in the natural order of things. Capitalism is treated as an elemental force, like the wind and tides, or a mere

byproduct of human nature. The reality of power in today's society is hidden behind the mist generated by this false "naturalism."

The underlying principle, therefore, is clear: progressives need a fundamental critique of capitalism and an open discussion about the possible advantages of socialism—even to attempt major reforms within capitalism. And when they begin that critique, we believe, most progressives and most Americans will come to the conclusion that C.B. Macpherson, in his *The Life and Times of Liberal Democracy*, reached some four decades ago: It is increasingly difficult to reconcile liberal democratic values (much less anything remotely resembling genuine democracy) with today's monopoly-finance capital. Something has to go. And that is exactly why capitalism is off-limits to honest discussion, and why the constraints placed on public debate in our political culture prevent any real, permanent forward movement.¹⁸ We know that most of those self-identified as part of the U.S. liberal-left are very privileged, relative to the larger working population. The liberal-left is heavily entrenched in the professional-managerial stratum, or the upper middle class. Many of them are employed by the state. Theirs is a class reality that ties them in innumerable ways to the system. They may want significant change, but most of the liberal-left is materially linked, in a way that the vast majority of the population is not, to the existing power structure. Nevertheless, there is no imaginable path toward socialism in the United States today, in which a considerable portion of those who currently constitute the "liberal-left" do not play an important role as key initiators and supporters of a general revolt in society.

The current state of U.S. politics might be described as one in which the right has gained more power by moving right. The left needs to gain more power by moving left. If this means increased political polarization, so be it.

Getting Serious

We were provoked to write this article because the possibilities in the United States for a genuine, free-wheeling discussion of capitalism's defects, and the merits of socialism, are greater today than at any time in generations, and we must not let this historic moment pass. What is striking, and a cause for optimism, is the current degree of criticism of capitalism and the amount of support for socialism—in a media and political culture where criticism of the former and support for the latter have been all but forbidden. Back in 1987, a poll of the U.S. population indicated that 45 percent of the population believed that Marx's famous words from the *Critique of the Gotha Programme* delimiting communism—"from each according to his ability, to each according to his needs"—were enshrined in the U.S. Constitution. This, of course, said more about the absolute ideals of most Americans, and what they thought they should expect, than about the U.S. Constitution itself.¹⁹

Two decades of neoliberalism, far from eradicating radical ideas, appear to have given them rebirth. A 2009 global survey, conducted by the BBC, found some 15 percent of Americans agreed with the statement that free market capitalism "is fatally flawed and a different economic system is needed." Another 40 percent thought capitalism had problems that required regulation and reform. A mere 25 percent thought capitalism was doing a bang-up job and increased government regulation would be harmful.²⁰ The remainder weren't sure. A different 2009 survey found that only 53 percent of Americans thought capitalism superior to socialism. Among adults under

the age of thirty, capitalism was preferred to socialism as the best system, by a slim 37 to 33 percent margin.²¹

We are in no position to determine the veracity of these poll numbers, though they arise from what are considered respectable sources. We also can only imagine what people think when they hear the term "socialism," since it is either ignored or mangled in the mainstream culture. But we do know that people experience capitalism and corporate power every day in their lives, and these surveys demonstrate what we have seen repeatedly: People don't like it very much, despite the endless exhortations about the genius of "choice" made possible by the "free market" around them. To many millions of Americans, if socialism is the nemesis of capitalism it must by definition be a damn sight better.

To his credit, filmmaker Michael Moore was the first to tap into this sentiment with his 2009 film, *Capitalism: A Love Story*. He toured the nation, explaining that capitalism had failed and needed to be replaced. Words like these had never been uttered on commercial news media, unless they were part of some denunciation of the speaker.

Capitalism, as an economic, political, and social system based on private ownership, directed to the greatest possible profits for particular individuals and corporations, is, in our day, entirely absurd. It has no rational or orderly relationship to human life or to the future of humanity. Socialism, as its heir apparent, stands for the chance that still exists to create a just, egalitarian, and sustainable world directed at human needs, in which the people themselves are sovereign—once the fetters of private profit are burst asunder.

Is this possible? Who knows? What we do know is that, as long as we breathe air, we have no real choice but to rebel, because under capitalism humanity has no future.

John Bellamy Foster is editor of Monthly Review and professor of sociology at the University of Oregon. He is the author of many books on political economy, Marxism, and the environment, including his most recent Capitalism in the Anthropocene: Ecological Ruin or Ecological Revolution (2022).

Robert W. McChesney is the author of several books on media and politics, professor of communication at the University of Illinois, host of the weekly talk show, Media Matters, on WILL-AM radio, and cofounder of the media reform organization Free Press.

This essay was made available online by Monthly Review 1 June 2010. monthlyreview.org

Reflections on Being American

ELAHEH FARMAND

American flags sprout like trees and wildflowers in backyards and gardens, over and around fences and windows. Tall and grand, they surround diners and restaurants in Pennsylvania, impossible to ignore. With strong winds, they dance almost majestically.

What is the message of this flag, built on stolen land with the blood and genocide of its indigenous ancestors? What is the message of this flag of a country forged on the sweat and labor of immigrants and slaves? Is the message to announce one's Americanness? Is it to declare that settlers belong here despite America's violent birth? How does one claim Americanness knowing white settlers took this land with brute force, depriving the indigenous of their livelihood, their farms and sacred sources of water? America is a fabrication created out of the erasure of entire tribes and peoples. This is what I am reminded of when I see the American flag.

Why is there such an obsession with Americanness? If we criticize our government and speak up against its war crimes at home and abroad, we are deemed unpatriotic; as anti-imperialist activists and journalists, our reputations are tainted and marred. In America, dissent is not always welcomed. The obsession with patriotism has divided us as a people. The prospect of, and claim to, the American Dream has clouded our judgment.

What is the American Dream, and to whom does it belong? Is the dream to climb the proverbial ladder, predicated upon the growth of our personal capital? Is it to assert one's position in society with wealth and fame? Is it to birth another generation to reproduce the nuclear family? Is it to incur debts of all magnitudes so we can house our family in the American suburbs and proudly display multiple vehicles in our driveways?

My first memory of the American flag is from elementary school in Tehran, where our guardians* instructed us to stomp on the flag whilst chanting, "Death to America!" and thrusting our fists into the air. It was easier to make us believe that our enemy was another country rather than question our own. In fact, they dictated the teaching that the West, specifically America, had blood on its hands. In a song we recited often, it was our soldiers who bled because of American atrocities:

*Khooneh javananeh ma
michekad az changeh to!*

*The blood of our young
is dripping from your claws.*

* In Iran, a female school guardian's primary task is to enforce a moral code, ensuring that girls don't behave 'improperly' (e.g., no running during recess, no long or unkempt fingernails, no display of jewelry, and various other rules).

While I was told to hate America in school, at home, we were preparing to send my Baba to America in the hopes that American doctors could heal him. Baba's medical situation had worsened, and Iranian doctors were unable to determine the cause for his inability to walk without struggle. Baba seemed healthy and had always been a fast walker, but he had started to experience pain, and had to stop for frequent breaks, even while simply descending the three flights of stairs from our apartment.

How was I to hate this America that I knew nothing of, other than these supposed crimes? Meanwhile, as soon-to-be immigrants, my family was hearing other narratives about America. America would be a place of opportunity and hope. I would later learn that my Maman had started concocting her own American Dream much earlier. When I asked Maman why we chanted "Death to America" at school, she said that we were against their government, but not their people. It was her way of comforting me, I recognized then. A government was more abstract in my mind and, therefore, less tangible to hate. But a nation of people? How can one ask a child to call upon the death of a nation of people? I gathered that the issue was more complicated, and we left it there.

Still, I had to do something about my dilemma in school. After the brief conversation with Maman, I returned to school with a plan. When we lined up for our morning routine before the first bell rang, I raised my fist in the air, amongst a sea of others, but my lips no longer moved to utter, "Marg bar America!" ("Death to America!") This small act of resistance felt like my personal weapon against disparaging the country we were soon to emigrate to, and where Maman would live her version of the American Dream.

~

Upon entering the American education system at 11 years-old, my classmates and I, all whose first language was not English, were instructed to learn the Pledge of Allegiance:

"I pledge allegiance, to the flag, of the United States of America, and to the republic, for which it stands, one nation, under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all."

While I didn't fully grasp the meaning of what I was told to memorize, I still found this ritual uncomfortable. It reminded me of my Iranian school guardians and teachers forcing us to believe what we were told without question. I began to dread this routine in American schools, standing every morning and reciting this pledge before class officially began. I wondered if I could find a way to avoid reciting it, the way I had done in Iran. I tried quieting my voice, but still moved my lips just enough to avoid suspicion; I had to be mindful in smaller classrooms where we stood under the teacher's watchful eyes.

How odd it was, to say death to a country and then enter that same country and be asked to pledge allegiance to its flag. Why is this flag such an important symbol? To this day, nearly 25 years since arriving in America, I still ask myself: Why do our neighbors feel compelled to adorn their homes and vehicles with the American flag?

In her exquisite memoir, *Home Bound*, Vanessa A. Bee explores this phenomenon:

“America against the world. How else to explain the obscene display of red, white, and blue flags in places that made no sense? Front lawns, large poles, T-shirts, license plates, eating plates, hats, baby onesies... It was as if America feared that people would forget where they lived, or the long road traveled from their country of origin to here.”

As a new immigrant, Bee then wonders if America’s insecurity is a result of the September 11 attacks, but a classmate reminds her that they were already pledging allegiance to the flag every day before the attacks.

The state has manufactured America’s insecurity to keep its people under surveillance and living in fear. If the enemy is always another country, the enemy can never be within our own. If the newscasters and politicians bombard us with messages that warn of our “enemies abroad,” people start to believe it; or at least, are less inclined to question it. They become paranoid and insecure. Their American Dream comes under threat. The immigrants arriving become their worst nightmare: politicians and the media repeat the narrative that the immigrant is taking their jobs away; the immigrant is committing crimes. The non-English languages they hear become a threat to their culture; “otherness” undermines their claim to the American way of life. To protect their American Dream, their culture, their home and their land, they plant flags in their yards, not merely for decoration, but to remind themselves and their children that no one can take their hopes and dreams away. The once indigenous land is theirs to claim:

*“This land is your land, this land is my land
From California to the New York Island,
From the redwood forest to the Gulf Stream waters;
This land was made for you and me.”*

—Woody Guthrie

As a nation, America needs to accept its violent past. Schools need to teach our children the true history of how America came to be. We need to accept that we never successfully erased racism. Nor did we rid ourselves of slavery; we have continued to wage a war on black America: holding black people as modern slaves in our prison systems. We need to demand reparations from our government for all of the peoples whose lives and livelihoods we’ve destroyed. When the police arrive with brute force to fight with tribes who are still trying to protect their land and water, we must stand with the people in solidarity and resist. Americans don’t have to live in fear and with insecurity, but they must first acknowledge their ancestors’ sins and crimes against humanity. Every time pundits and politicians blame immigrants and people of color for a crime committed, or yet to be committed, we must undo their narrative by speaking up. America was created violently, yes. But it has the potential for beauty.

Individualism runs rampant in America and breeds ignorance and carelessness towards each other. We must reintroduce the collective. Collectively, we can fight

off racism. Collectively, we can love. Collectively, we can embrace the different languages and cultures that exist and make up America.

We can build a new and just American Dream that enriches and empowers us. For too long, Americans have been told that the American Dream is to take pride in pulling themselves up by their bootstraps, no matter the cost. In 2005, then-president George W. Bush told a divorced mother of three:

“You work three jobs? Uniquely American, isn’t it? I mean, that is fantastic that you’re doing that.”

Let’s rewrite a new American Dream where we as a collective have free and equal access to basic human needs, universal necessities: healthcare, quality education, financial security, dignified retirement, adequate and secure housing, quality transportation, ample time to spend with loved ones, childcare, and meaningful work that meets the needs of a healthy and sustainable society, not the greed of shareholders and CEOs.

Elaheh Farmand is an Iranian immigrant and writer. In 2016, she founded the series, “Immigrants & Exile: Stories of Nostalgia & Longing”. The series gives space for people to share their experiences of nostalgia, exile, and longing. Elaheh fights for and dreams of a society restructured to place people’s needs and wellbeing before profits. She is occasionally nostalgic for her childhood in Iran, but focuses her energy on organizing, connecting with her community, her family and friends.

What struck me as I began to study history was how nationalist fervor — inculcated from childhood on by pledges of allegiance, national anthems, flags waving and rhetoric blowing — permeated the educational systems of all countries, including our own.

—Howard Zinn

Two Barrels Aim at African People's Socialist Party

DON FITZ

With new FBI and Department of “Justice” (DOJ) attacks expected in early January, a defense, mobilization and information session attracted hundreds of allies of the African People's Socialist Party (APSP). On Friday, December 23 they zoomed into the “Emergency Mass Meeting: Hands Off Uhuru! Hands Off Africa!” The APSP told its supporters that it expects indictments in early January 2023 and possibly sooner.

Indictments could include many more than the four names listed as “unindicted co-conspirators” during raids of July 29, 2022: Chairman Omali Yeshitela, Party Director of Agitation and Propaganda Akilé Anai, African People's Solidarity Committee Chair Penny Hess and Uhuru Solidarity Movement Chair Jesse Nevel.

At 5 am that morning, [the FBI invaded](#) multiple St. Louis locations, including the private residence of Omali Yeshitela and his wife and APSP Deputy Chair Ona Zené Yeshitela and the Uhuru Solidarity Center, as well as the Uhuru House in St. Petersburg FL.

During the December 23 webinar, Yeshitela vividly recalled that flashbang grenades were set off and laser points were directed at his chest when he opened the door of their home, and a drone almost hit Ona when she came down the stairs. Both of them were handcuffed and the entire Black working-class St. Louis neighborhood was under siege for hours. The federal agents seized all of their devices, such as computers and phones, thereby seriously hampering their political work.

As reported by [Toward Freedom](#), in St. Petersburg FBI agents lured Akilé Anai “outside her home, saying her car had been broken into. Upon opening her car, they forced her to hand over her devices.”

The FBI and DOJ claimed that the raids were sparked by Yeshitela's having conversations with Aleksandr Ionov, a Russian they accused of spreading “Russian propaganda.” During the webinar Yeshitela described how insulting and demeaning it was to insinuate that the APSP is unable to analyze African people's state of oppression and make decisions for itself but can only reach conclusions after Russians tell it what to think.

This is particularly chilling for those who do solidarity work with Latin America, Africa and Asia. According to the precedent set by the July 29 raids and indictments, anyone who meets with any representative of another country could face criminal charges under the Foreign Agent Registration Act, which the APSP expects to be used to justify their bullying. Actions against the APSP could lay the foundation for indicting me for interviewing and writing about Cuban doctors.

Legal abuse could be leveled against everyone else who has visited the island and explained what the revolution has accomplished. The FBI/DOJ could indict Monthly Review [Press](#) for publishing my book on [Cuban Health Care](#) along with every other publisher who releases books on Cuba, Venezuela, Colombia and other countries that have resisted US imperialism.

A noticeable exception would be citizens and lawmakers who meet with and are influenced by agents of Israel. They have no reason to fear harassment. Of course, it might be quite different for those having the temerity to meet with Palestinians.

After the raids, the [Black Alliance for Peace](#) announced that it would “concentrate its efforts on not only opposing the U.S. war agenda globally but the war and repression being waged on Black and Brown communities within U.S. borders.”

A major purpose of the December 23 webinar was to build nationwide and international support for the July 29 victims so people are prepared to respond when the indictments come down. In light of this, the Green Party of St. Louis issued a statement which appears below. Following it are the APSP's “Principles of Unity” which it asks organizations to endorse. You can communicate your support at the website [handsoffuhuru.org](#).

The Other Barrel

What is written above only describes one barrel of the corporate state's shotgun. The other barrel consists of efforts to shut down the many projects under the APSP umbrella. They simultaneously offer meaningful life-changing needs for those in poor Black US communities and provide examples of what a socialist society could look like.

The projects are part of what the APSP calls its “[Black Power Blueprint](#)” (BPB) and what socialist theorists might call “concretization” of its ideas which “prefigure” a post-capitalist society. The BPB's efforts may be the most extensive integration of theory and practice occurring in the US today.

Perhaps the prime example is Uhuru Wa Kulea ([African Women's Health Center](#)) which has a vision “to provide health and self-care programs that reinforce our traditional African culture, and invest in the future of our community with doula and childbirth educator certification programs along with opportunities for employment and entrepreneurship.” Concepts for the Center rely heavily on the health care system of Cuba, which now has [life expectancy](#) greater than the US, due to its focus on women and children.

APSP-related efforts also include

- The [Uhuru House Community Center](#) which transformed a condemned building into a three-story community event and program space named [Akwaaba Hall](#);
- A [Community Basketball Court](#) to allow for “spirited youth programs” and tournaments;
- Murals at the Gary Brooks [Community Garden](#) that has been in operation for two years and at the recently completed Community Basketball Court which depict “Black families controlling our own culture and food economy by planting, growing and harvesting food from the garden”;
- Completed renovation of a 4-plex apartment building devoted to housing for the African Independence [Workforce Program](#) which creates jobs for those re-entering the Black community from the prison system;
- The [Uhuru Jiko Kitchen and Bakery/Café](#) which, once the refurbishing of an existing commercial structure is completed, will bring African economic and cultural life to a depressed commercial area and will help stop gentrification;

- A planned program for the [Black Power Square](#) where condemned buildings have been removed to make way for retail opportunities by utilizing shipping containers to house community-based small businesses and create jobs.

The above are in St. Louis. APSP also runs [Uhuru Foods and Pies](#) in Oakland CA and St. Petersburg FL, a community garden/farm in Huntsville AL, [furniture stores](#) in Oakland CA and Philadelphia PA, a [radio station](#) in St. Petersburg FL and the [Burning Spear](#) newspaper.

The goal of attacking the APSP leaders is to exterminate every project and every component of the BPB which Omali Yeshitela speaks of as “building duel and contending power,” funded to a significant degree through reparations raised by the Uhuru Solidarity Movement (USM). The government, of course, has virtually unlimited police and legal resources at its disposal to drown out dissent. If it can force the APSP to divert its energies and limited budget to its legal defense, the FBI/DOJ can undermine projects and terrorize solidarity activists even if it imprisons very few.

This is the message from one barrel of the snarling state:

“Don’t hope for a new life ...

“don’t imagine a new world...

“and certainly don’t try to build one ...

“because capitalism is all you can look forward to.”

The other barrel of the shotgun screams that efforts by US citizens to build solidarity with victims of global oppression will be met with the most vicious attacks the corporate state can muster.

Don Fitz (fitzdon@aol.com) is on the Editorial Board of [Green Social Thought](#), where a version of this article [originally appeared](#). He was the 2016 candidate of the Missouri Green Party for Governor. His book, [Cuban Health Care: The Ongoing Revolution](#), has been available since June 2020.

Statement by Don Fitz on behalf of the Green Party of St. Louis, December 23, 2022.

The Green Party of St. Louis fully agrees with the right of African people to advocate and organize for the unification, liberation and self-determination of Africa and African People as laid out in the “Principles of Unity.”

The FBI raid of July 29 was not just against the APSP. It was an attack on all working for social justice and liberation.

As has happened many times before, governmental violence was unleashed first against Black/African victims to serve as an example.

The Biden administration is fully responsible for opening one of the most repressive eras in US history.

We would have to go back to the racist president Woodrow Wilson and his imprisonment of Eugene Debs to find a case of people being arrested so blatantly for their political beliefs.

Even during the US war against Viet Nam, people were not arrested merely for listening to Vietnamese views or visiting North Viet Nam.

The current actions of the Biden administration are a message that no one can question his proxy war against Russia — a message that Americans have lost the right to make their own decisions.

The events of July 29, 2022 are meant to intimidate any who stand in solidarity with movements and countries who are struggling for their liberation, such as Cuba.

They are warning that the same could happen to supporters of revolutionary Venezuela.

The FBI raids are a threat to those who defend the right of Nicaragua to chart its own course.

Indictment of Uhuru members aids and abets those criminals who overthrew the democratically elected government in Peru on Dec 7, 2022.

Biden’s proxy war against Russia gives lie to his supposed opposition to climate change. One of the real reasons for Biden’s “Hate Russia!” campaign is to allow US corporations to corner the market of fossil fuels in Ukraine and force Europe to buy US natural gas at absurdly high prices.

Under Evo Morales, Bolivia sought to control its own lithium, a critical element for “alternative” energy. When he was violently overthrown, the Trump/Biden supporter Elon Musk (of Tesla fame) proclaimed “We will coup whoever we want!”

The great majority of the world’s cobalt, also essential for “alternative” energy, lies in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (home to many other essential minerals). Efforts of the Biden administration to destroy the APSP reveals his plan for anyone who advocates self-determination for Africa.

Principles of Unity

- We unite with the right of African people to advocate and organize for the unification, liberation and self-determination of Africa and African People.
- We denounce the FBI and US government’s attacks on the African Liberation Movement historically and currently
- We demand that the US government drop the charges against any member of the African People’s Socialist Party, the Uhuru Movement and those named and implied in the indictment and warrants
- We demand the return of all confiscated property to the Uhuru Movement and compensation for damages and payment of reparations for the attacks
- We demand an end to FBI surveillance and infiltration of the Uhuru Movement and release of all documents on the Uhuru Movement since the 1960s
- We denounce the assault on the anti-colonial activity and programs of the African People’s Socialist Party/Uhuru Movement such as the Black Power Blueprint and other economic institutions and projects.

Find out more about the repression!

Christians as Dangerous Good Samaritans

GARY OLSON

Lately, I've been musing about religion and politics. And more specifically, the thought that keeps recurring to me is the following: Is the idea of born agains and other Christians becoming political radicals, a far-fetched one? Or, should the question be, how could they not become politically radical Christians?

One sees frequent references to the large number of white, born again Christians who voted for Trump and the unmistakable inference is that there is a deep, principled gap between these folks and so-called political "radicals" that can never be bridged. For whatever reasons, that may be true for some, but I refuse to buy this sweeping generalization as the final word.

To state my case from the outset: Whatever other difference may exist about some issues, my understanding of what Jesus was all about and what honest Christians should take from his message, inclines me to believe that common cause is not only consistent but the best path forward for realizing what should be shared goals.

Economic elites, abetted by some faith leaders, have taken over Christianity and transformed it into a state religion which functions to legitimate and further their rule. And I won't mince words out of fear that some might take offense: The principles of our capitalist economic system and the irreducible core of Jesus's teaching are irreconcilable.

As a child growing up in northern Great Plains, my own religious training was in the American Lutheran church, the most fundamentalist of the synods within Lutheranism. This was the faith my grandparents brought from Scandinavia, especially rural Norway, where it was known as the "Dark Religion." There was a heavy emphasis on sin, scripture, the devil and a stern judgmental God. I recall attending weeklong, summer Bible camps where I was "saved" more than once at campfire revival meetings. Later, I attended a private Lutheran high school and Lutheran college, both steeped in fundamentalist Lutheran doctrine.

From childhood on, I heard Jesus's parable of the Good Samaritan countless times in Sunday School and subsequently in sermons and required chapel and religion courses. If there's a bedrock principle in the Gospels, this famous parable is it. According to Luke 10: 24-37, Jesus told the parable as part of a Socratic dialogue with an expert in Jewish law. The lawyer asks Jesus how to attain eternal life, a question that Jesus turns on the lawyer, asking him, "What is written in the law?" The lawyer cites Deuteronomy 6:5 about loving God with all one's heart, soul, strength, and mind but then adds "and your neighbor as yourself." That's it, replies Jesus. But then, the lawyer asks, desiring to justify himself and perhaps trip up Jesus, "Who is my neighbor?" The lawyer may have wanted Jesus to demarcate some specific boundaries, thus enabling him to ignore everyone outside of them.

Rather than a direct answer, Jesus responds with the parable:

"A certain man" (probably Jewish) is walking down the seventeen mile road from Jerusalem to Jericho, a treacherous area known locally as "The Bloody Pass" where bandits were known to prey on travelers. The man is severely beaten, robbed of his clothes, and left half dead by the side of the road. At this point, two highly regarded figures from the Jewish community come along. The first to arrive was a priest who "passed by to the other side of the road." Soon, a Levite (a priest's helper) comes along but he also continues "on the other side." Eventually, a stranger from Samaria stops by to help the robbery victim. Here it's important to note the long standing enmity between Israelites and Samaritans, to the point where the two people had virtually no social contact. The Jews despised the Samaritans as apostates and the hatred was mutual. Undoubtedly, Jesus knew that his audience would find it incredible that a Samaritan would be the paragon of virtue in the parable.

The Samaritan administers first aid to the victim, takes him to an inn, and remains with him overnight. He even gives the innkeeper two denari (roughly two days wages) for any bills incurred by the man and even promises that on his return trip he'll reimburse the innkeeper for any additional expenses. At the end of the parable, Jesus asks the lawyer which of the three men behaved as the good neighbor to the victim. Probably squirming a bit and unable to utter the word "Samaritan," the lawyer replied, "The man who had mercy on him." And with that, Jesus tells the lawyer—and by extension, us—"Go and do likewise."

For many years, perhaps like most people who hear the parable, I took it as a "Jesus wants us to help others trope," a feel good story that a decent person should follow the Good Samaritan's example and come to the aid of others, even at some personal risk. However, it wasn't until reading Dr. Martin Luther King Jr.'s updating of the parable that I began to appreciate just how much Jesus was a counter-culture revolutionary. I also began to recognize its updated applicability, especially when grounded in a wider socioeconomic context. Without invoking any supernatural dimension to the parable, we know there is overwhelming evidence that (almost) all people have an innate capacity for empathy. Empathy is central to the story because it's about being able to feel, imagine and identify with the pain of others and then engage in the appropriate response. And in the parable imparted by Jesus, the Samaritan didn't act because of religious beliefs but was "moved by compassion."

In our world, with all of its victims lying by the side of the road, the parable raises at least two additional lessons. First, the Samaritan didn't consult a checklist of prohibited victims like undocumented worker, those with different sexual orientations, accent, skin color, political or religious affiliation, whether he was pro-life or a member of a marginalized community. Dr. King frequently preached about the Good Samaritan, invariably sourcing "Love Thy Neighbor" within a moral universalism and we know it's the unifying moral principle in all the world's great religions, including Christianity.

Second, and this directly relates to my purpose here, King cautioned that while philanthropy is commendable we can't "overlook the circumstances which makes philanthropy necessary."

In other words, King is suggesting that the problem is as much the identity of the robbers and the treacherous journey taken by the injured man. It's apparent King is suggesting that, yes, helping the injured roadside victim is laudatory but that Jesus also means one's neighbor is "any needy man on one of the numerous Jericho roads of life." King is updating the parable to mean all victims of injustice and calling out modern day pillagers and plunderers here in the United States. Jesus's admonition of "Go and do likewise" takes on new meaning because making the world more conducive to loving our neighbors requires one to practice what I've termed elsewhere "dangerous empathy."

King and Jesus's Jericho Road is a metaphor for radical change and as such, embodies dangerous empathy—radical love in action. Adding the adjective "dangerous" permits the parable to rise to the level of a moral stimulus package. Dangerous, because the wealthy, powerful and privileged elite in this country can't allow such ideas to gain purchase. Just as the powers of the time saw Jesus as a threat, those promoting dangerous empathy today are branded subversive, anti-American radicals.

One doesn't find the word "radical" in the Scriptures but the original meaning of the word describes precisely how Dr. King interpreted the meaning of the parable. And here it's instructive to parse and get beyond the divisive and often misused word, radical. Those who own and control virtually everything that matters our country are quick to label any critics as "radical" in an effort to stigmatize and discredit them. However, the original definition of radical comes from the Latin *radicalis*, from *radix*, or root or as in someone speaking or writing about fundamental truths. The tie-in with the Good Samaritan parable means going beyond addressing symptoms to identifying and doing something about the root causes of our neighbors' suffering. My take is that honest Christians must unapologetically assert that Jesus's message is totally at odds with society's dominant culture.

Parenthetically, for this undertaking, it won't do for liberals or "progressives" who identify as Christians to adopt an overweening, censorious attitude toward more conservative Christians. I say that for a reason, again grounded in Scripture, but with a important contemporary political turn. In his Sermon on the Mount, Jesus said "How can you say to your brother, 'Let me take the mote out of your own eye,' when there is a beam in your own eye? You hypocrite, first take the log out of your own eye, then you will see clearly to take the speck out of your brother's eye." (Matthew 7: 1-5 KJV).

The modern twist is that the beam or plank is the Democratic Party to which many liberals and "progressives" remain attached. A blinders-free Christian will acknowledge, along with Black Agenda Report's Danny Haiphong, that "The Democratic Party is where movements go to die and where austerity is given a friendly, more diverse face from which to shatter the lives of working class people." Although advertising itself as the party of compassion, even the mild reformism of the Sanders' campaign was fiercely opposed by the Democratic establishment. And as Haiphong

reminds us, the so-called progressive "Resistance" within the party refuses to confront the fact that "The U.S. state is the enforcement mechanism of capitalism."

Nixon campaign strategist Kevin Phillips once called the Democrats "history's second most enthusiastic capitalist party" but it's certainly as pro-capitalist as the Republicans. The first and last allegiance of national level Democrats is to Wall Street, to the establishment of which they're charter members. In the words of political historian Lance Serfa, rather than undertaking radical measures to help marginalized people and working class Americans, the Democratic Party seeks to "corral them and ensure that they don't strike out as an independent party." Written in 2012, we need only substitute "sheep herding them" for "corral them" to update it. In short, the Democratic Party functions as a political prophylactic seeking to prevent deep and desperately needed structural change. For Christians this would mean distrusting the state and its official religion of the market and all its attendant myths.

Finally, lest I be misunderstood, this does not mean hating plutocrats and their enablers or wishing that physical harm is visited upon them. It does mean Christians becoming dangerous Good Samaritans, working to dismantle a system that values profits over humanity and replacing it with a democratic one that's responsive to people's needs. Acknowledging these truths might prove a cathartic, liberating and for many, even a secular atonement experience. Can I get an "Amen?"

Gary Olson is Professor Emeritus of Political Science at Moravian University, Bethlehem, PA. He can be reached at: olsong@moravian.edu.

Originally published in Dandelion Salad, December 2021.

The Homestead Steel Strike

LENNY FLANK

By the 1890s, the United States, which had been a largely agricultural society, had been transformed into a rapidly expanding industrial powerhouse, with factories and mills sprouting up in every urban area. The US became a lopsided economy, with a small handful of super-rich making immense profits from a great mass of poorly paid and ill-treated immigrant workers. The result was a series of strikes and industrial warfare, which came to a head in Pittsburgh PA.

The steel industry was the heart of the American economy—and the city of Pittsburgh was the heart of the steel industry. One of the largest steel mills in the city was the Homestead Works, over 200 acres, in the suburb of Homestead. It was owned by Andrew Carnegie.

Carnegie liked to present himself as a benevolent philanthropist who treated his workers well. He also liked to tell the press that he was a supporter of a worker's right to organize into unions. But in all of his steel mills, he had himself ruthlessly stamped out any efforts to unionize. The Homestead Mill was different, however—when he bought the plant in 1883, it was already unionized with the Amalgamated Association of Iron and Steel Workers. It was a situation that Carnegie, who liked to personally oversee and control every detail of his mill operations, could not tolerate.

In the summer of 1892, the mill's labor contract with the Amalgamated Union was about to expire, and Carnegie saw his chance to break the union. Before sailing to Europe for his yearly holiday, he appointed his company partner Henry Frick as his representative in the negotiations and instructed Frick to take a hard line. Neither of them wanted to share any management power with a labor union.

Frick, who had previously built up an empire of coal companies, was well-known for his ready use of private “security forces” and scabs to break strikes. Now, with Carnegie's blessing, he followed the same strategy with the Amalgamated. First, he gave a “take it or leave it” offer to the Union outlining large wage cuts, which he knew they could not possibly agree to. And when the “negotiations” broke down as expected, Frick ended the talks and on June 30 imposed a “lockout”, firing all the union members and hiring non-union “scabs” to replace them.

The result was war—and Frick had already prepared for it. Even as the “negotiations” were going on, Frick had constructed a 10-foot fence, with barbed wire, gun loopholes and guard towers, completely around the three-mile perimeter of the Homestead Mill, intended to keep strikers and union organizers out. The steel workers dubbed it “Fort Frick”. As a “security force” to police their perimeter, the company approached the famous Pinkerton Detective Agency, which was asked to provide what was in essence a privately-run army. (The local police from the town of Homestead, Frick knew, could not be relied upon, since most of the police officers—as well as the town's Mayor—were former steel workers and union men.) Union members, in turn, appeared in city streets with guns, and although the Union

leaders made a public pledge of “no violence”, they also declared that they would “gently but firmly” prevent any scab replacement workers from entering the mill. The stage was set for a civil war.

In a series of telegrams to Carnegie, who was vacationing in Scotland, Frick laid out his plan. The Pinkerton Agency would send 300 armed men, who would be brought up the Monongahela River, secretly in the dead of night to avoid a confrontation with the Union. Once the Pinkertons had entered the mill and established a protected perimeter, Frick would send in his scab replacement workers to start the plant running again. With all its members locked out and jobless, the Amalgamated Iron and Steel Workers Union would be no more. The Pinkertons would make their move on the evening of July 5.

But the Union, with its widespread support among the public, had an excellent intelligence system, quickly found out about Frick's scheme, and made preparations to meet it. When the 300-armed Pinkertons (most of them newly hired just for this assignment) made their way upriver on July 5, in two barges, the steel workers were ready. By 4am, a group of several thousand strikers, armed with pistols, hunting rifles, sledgehammers, iron bars, knives, and whatever else they could find, gathered at the Homestead Mill's dock, hiding behind fences and pieces of machinery.

As the two barges made their way to the dock, they were pelted with bricks and rocks. The first Pinkerton to step off the boat was met by a Union official, who told them, “Stop now, or there will be bloodshed”. The two groups of armed men faced each other in a tense standoff.

Then somebody fired a shot. (Both sides blamed each other, and it's not certain who it was.)

Chaos broke out. The Pinkertons retreated to the shelter of the barges, while the Union men ran behind Fort Frick's wall. The gunfire lasted for ten minutes before there was a lull. But rather than retreating, the Pinkertons tried once again, after a few hours, to leave the barges and make their way ashore. Gunfire erupted again. As the sun came up, a huge crowd of townspeople gathered on the far shore to watch the battle: spectators sat on chairs as if watching a baseball game. Nearly all were cheering for the Union men. The strikers at Homestead were soon reinforced by fellow steelworkers from nearby Pittsburgh.

The Homestead workers, meanwhile, having pinned down the Pinkertons inside the barges, now attempted to sink the boats right there in the river. First, they piled a small raft with oil-soaked rags, set it alight, and tried to float it downstream to set the barges on fire. Next they tried to push a flaming railroad cart into the side of the Pinkerton boats. Somebody found a few sticks of dynamite in a tool shed, and somebody else found an old cannon which the workers loaded with bits of scrap steel. (The cannoners managed only to kill one of their own fellow workers who was standing nearby.)

At this point, the captain of the tugboat who had pulled the barges to the dock now decided that he had had enough, and he cut his tow ropes and fled, leaving the engineless barges helplessly adrift. Several times, the Pinkertons tried to show a white flag to surrender—but the gunfire continued. It wasn't until 12 hours of combat that the crowd of steel workers agreed to allow the Pinkertons to leave the barges, drop their weapons, and surrender. They were marched away by a column of townspeople,

who couldn't resist clubbing their hated enemies with sticks and rocks. "You could almost hear the skulls crack", one newspaper reported. The Pinkertons all left town on the very next train. The barges they had occupied were burnt and sank. The "Battle of Homestead" had resulted in 7 dead steelworkers and 3 dead Pinkertons.

For a time, it seemed as if the workers had won. Armed Union men now patrolled "Frick's Fort", guarding against any further attempts to reopen the Mill. But public opinion, which had almost universally condemned the steel company's use of a private army to break the strike, was not supportive of the occupation of the mill by the strikers. Carnegie, meanwhile, while telling the press that he did not approve of the use of armed men to provoke violence, also sent Frick a private message supporting him.

Frick, meanwhile, now turned to the Governor of Pennsylvania. Arguing that Homestead was in a state of "insurrection", he convinced the Governor to send 8500 National Guard troops to "maintain order". The militiamen arrived on July 12, imposed martial law, and quickly secured the Mill while arresting over 100 Union leaders and town officials on charges ranging from murder to treason. Within days, the steel mill was back in operation with non-union labor. Carnegie had gotten what he wanted. The former union workers were offered the chance to return to their old jobs—if they could prove they had not participated in the violence and if they signed an anti-union pledge. Nobody took up the offer.

The Homestead Strike closed with an odd postscript. On July 23, an anarchist from Chicago named Alexander Berkman, seeking revenge for the dead strikers, entered Frick's office in Pittsburgh, shot him twice and stabbed him with a dagger. Frick survived, and the assassination attempt, almost overnight, swung public opinion against unionists, anarchists, socialists, and radicals of every sort. One Union official was heard to remark that while Berkman hadn't killed Frick, he had managed to kill the Homestead Strike. In November, five months after the battle on the Monongahela River, the locked-out steel workers agreed to return to work on Carnegie's terms. "Our victory," Frick cabled to Carnegie, "is now complete."

Lenny is a longtime labor organizer and environmental, social, and antiwar activist. He was a founder of the Lehigh Valley IWW in the early 1990s.

Join us via Zoom 6:30–8:30 PM on Fridays
for political discussions and Thursdays to watch
and discuss significant films and politics.

(Zoom link moravian.zoom.us/j/8075321907)



Left Turn is a publication of Beyond Capitalism. You can subscribe for \$25 per year to receive every issue by mail! Email leftturn@sustainlv.org with your name and address. Donations are also welcome!

We accept articles of 500–2500 words in electronic format. Please include a short author bio and email your submission to leftturn@sustainlv.org.

Check out our sister publication!



The Alliance's *Sustainable Lehigh Valley* booklet now features creative writing and visual art in addition to essays, plus information about local organizations that help make our communities more sustainable.

While the sciences provide knowledge to make key decisions, they often fail to capture people's interest or help us see the ethical and moral dimensions. Stories, poetry, and visual art catch people's attention—and boost real difference in engagement and awareness.

Stand in solidarity with our Councilmember (Versus voices of white supremacy/death...)

RAYMOND NAT TURNER

I.

Distant echoes—Sun revolving ‘round flat
Earth— ‘round Inquisition; witch-burning;
‘round bubonic plague— ‘round pre-printing
press politics...

Embalmed voices—decomposing pogrom tones—
crunch like dry leaves beneath boots of Strike-tober;
beneath street heat of George Floyd Summer; beneath
Occupy; Arab Spring— beneath history’s forward march...

II.

Prancing peacock proud, tiny stickers boasted,
“I VOTED—”
Hired her to argue and
Fight for us. Sent her to City Hall. Tolt her, “Say
what we say...” Axed her, “Amplify Our voices—
Speak truth and Voice Our choices—
while we work; babysit; help with homework; care
for loved ones/neighbors; make art, money, love, babies.”

Suddenly, sunup to sundown King Cotton voices spit
Bullwhip white noise; Spit 1619 stripes at Black backs... again...
plantation overseer voices—
Civil War amputation without anesthesia voices; Leaking
faucet, running toilet voices; Artificial intelligence/false
consciousness voices call... again...

Asthmatic nazi phlegm voices call... again...
Wheezing, wicked, weaponized, “I can’t breathe!”
Jangling, quavering, nicotine hoarse, death squad
soldier, plastic police voices call... again...
Scowling, steely, tinny fingernails across chalkboard voices;
Glock muzzle mouths to burner phone voices call... again...

Gravelly, gaslit, graveyard, good guy with gun voices
call... again... Troll farm, tiki torch, bestial, bear
spray, January 6th, criminal, Charlottesville voices call... again...
Pacific-prowling aircraft carrier filled with shit voices call... again...
Nasal, hollow, clean coal, fracking fluid/fart voices call... again...
Death rattle, decomposing system on life support voices call... again...
But, hissing, filibustering, burning cross voices—Jim Crow,
Bull Connor, Tulsa, Rosewood, Red Summer, lynching voices
will not rob us of representation.... again...
Bloody Mary, banana republican poll tax, “How many bubbles
in a bar of soap?” “How many jelly beans in a jar?” voices will
not disenfranchise us.... again...

Hair in the game...

RAYMOND NAT TURNER

Stench of burning burkas accompanying rhythms
of swishing scissors shearing sable curls, wavy
brown manes, straight tresses salt and pepper,
And locks of sundry shades of grey and white.
Harmonizing with soprano shouts of “Death To
The Dictator!” morphing from cries for
Equal rights exploding in Red Sea streets...

Iranians are rising again! Rising in prerequisite
Movements...Maybe it's a flashback—1909?
Maybe it's a Mosaddegh moment? Maybe more?
Maybe this is it? Maybe it's the next one?

Some of us remember Iranian demonstrations—
circa late 70s. Brilliant/militant feats of flesh and
Blood engineering...
Young and strong. Marching all night long—
thru twists and turns, staunch slogan soundtracks;
Playing cat and mouse out cul-de-sac traps set
by San Francisco's political police—Truncheoned
thugs whose hand-eye coordination with the Shah's
SAVAK intelligence tentacles reached out from icy fog

Some of us remember marchers' names. Firouz, Mansour,
Mahdi, Azad...

remember they spoke English—but read the Germans in
Farsi.

Some of us remember standing in solidarity with them as
the peacock throne collapsed
Under gargantuan weight of street heat/fire of millions of
Feet in the street.

Some of us remember our comrades' and friends' rapture—
rushing home and rejoicing—
Never to be heard from again...

Today we stand in solidarity with women who have hair in
The Game—Women marching through
Mushroom clouds of teargas, tsunamis of lead—Red Seas of
Death—resisting misogynist mullahs and murderous 'morality'
Police...To topple theocratic thugs wrapped in robes of graft
Today we stand in solidarity with hearts/souls/spines of the
Common People:
Mothers, daughters, sisters, wives of warehouse workers—
of bus and truck drivers, of train operators—fierce fighters—
Once again on their long and winding road of revolution...
friction lubricated by oil workers throwing themselves in the
Resistance

Martyred Mahsa Amini's the Rock of Gibraltar bloodthirsty clerics
lifted
to
drop
on
Their own scarlet-stained sandals, crimson-covered combat boots—
TEACHing
Us how we must take on our own Texas Taliban/Florida fundamentalists...

*Raymond Nat Turner is Black Agenda Report's poet in residence and an accomplished
performing artist. You can find much more of his work at upsurgejazz.com*

economic (promoting economic development of the territories). To its credit, it states that the proponents of these approaches “conflate root causes and symptoms” and ignore “the very system through which Israel rules over the Palestinians.” The Report points out the limitations of the charge of apartheid when leveled only at the conditions of rule over the occupied Palestinian territories, urging instead “a holistic examination of the experience of the Palestinian people as a whole.” It states that the Israeli intention to dispossess, displace, subjugate, dominate, and replace the indigenous Palestinians with Israeli nationals “is the hallmark of settler-colonialism.” It is this settler colonial nature of the Israeli state that violates the fundamental right of the Palestinian people to develop free from Israeli domination.

As the Report states:

Colonialism, a phenomenon often disguised as a “civilization project” and historically imposed by “Western countries” on “third world” countries, was achieved through cultural subordination of the natives, economic exploitation of their land and resources and suffocation of their political claims. Colonialism is characterized as “settler” when also driven by the logic of elimination of the indigenous character of the colonized land. This manifests in the establishment and promotion of colonies, namely, settlements of foreign people implanted among the indigenous population with the aim of subjugating and dispossessing the natives and “permanently securing hold” over specific areas. The violation of the peoples’ right to self-determination is inherent to settler-colonialism.

Furthermore, in relation to the two-state solution, the Report makes clear that “Exercising the right to self-determination in the form of a politically independent State in all of the occupied Palestinian territory would be a minimum requirement of justice for the Palestinian people; yet its realization is as distant as ever, largely because of settler-colonial endeavors pursued by Israel.”

No doubt this is a welcome UN report for those seeking justice for the Palestinians. But the stubborn facts are that as I write (a) the most rightwing, religious, and racist governing coalition has come to power in Israel, returning Benjamin Netanyahu to power once more, and (b) the US is unlikely to shift its full support for Israel even when Israeli recalcitrance and racism is reaching its zenith. On December 29, 2022, the White House released a statement from President Biden on the new Israeli government. (See: <https://www.whitehouse.gov/briefing-room/statements-releases/2022/12/29/statement-from-president-joe-biden-on-the-new-government-of-the-state-of-israel/>) It stated: “I look forward to working with Prime Minister Netanyahu, who has been my friend for decades, to jointly address the many challenges and opportunities facing Israel and the Middle East region, including threats from Iran.” Biden went on to reiterate the administration’s hollow support for “the two-state solution” and its opposition to “policies that endanger its viability or contradict our mutual interests and values.”

But, as the UN report states: “The normative framework of self-determination, especially as affirmed in the context of decolonization processes, provides the necessary lens to (re-)examine and resolve the legitimate claims to emancipation of the Palestinian people.”

Holding Israel accountable requires putting an end to its settler-colonial policies.

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

Arab American & Palestinian American Leaders Meet With US Secretary of State Anthony Blinken

On January 27, 2023, Arab-Americans, including Palestinian American leaders, met with Secretary of State Antony Blinken upon his invitation to discuss his upcoming trip to the Middle East on January 29, which will include stops in Egypt, Israel, and Palestine.

The discussion focused on the secretary’s agenda for his trip to the region, which has been upstaged by the recent Israeli undercover military raid in Jenin that resulted in the killing of 10 Palestinians, including civilians.

Discussions in the meeting were serious, frank, and substantive, and allowed the Arab-American participants to express their concerns about US policy objectives and statements regarding the situation in Palestine, and specifically the events in Jenin and the mass displacement of Palestinians from Masafer Yatta in the West Bank. The group made it clear to the secretary that the US has a responsibility to act to restrain Israel’s aggressive behaviors toward the captive Palestinian people. Decades of US acquiescence to Israel’s policies of settlement expansion, land confiscation, home demolitions, and a range of other human rights violations have led to an Israeli sense of impunity and Palestinian despair. If the Administration is to fulfill its commitment to the equal worth of Israelis and Palestinians and their rights to security, prosperity, and dignity, the group insisted that the Secretary demonstrate firmness and resolve to rein in Israeli behavior.

Another central concern to the community are Israel’s ongoing efforts to gain admission to the U.S. visa waiver program. Last year, Israel published military rules regarding its restrictions on visitors to the West Bank which make clear that American citizens are discriminated against in entry to the West Bank if they indicate an intention to visit Palestinians. Those visiting Israelis face no similar restrictions.

As to the Department of State’s highlighted objective of the trip as that of encouraging Israel’s integration in the region, the participants urged the secretary to ensure that the rights of Palestinians be protected in any US supported regional integration projects. Recent polling on Arab public opinions (including AOI) shows widespread Arab rejection of normalization with Israel.

Finally, the community leaders emphasized their condemnation of antisemitism and hate crimes against the Jewish people and other vulnerable communities (including our own). They also expressed their deep concern with efforts to expand the definition of antisemitism to include criticism of Israeli policies and behavior. This conflation, they warned, was nothing more than a heavy-handed attempt to silence legitimate criticism of Israel.

The Arab American Institute is a national civil rights advocacy organization that provides strategic analysis to policymakers and community members to strengthen democracy, protect civil rights and liberties, and defend human rights. AAI organizes the 3.7 million Arab Americans across the country to ensure an informed, organized, and effective constituency is represented in all aspects of civic life. More information: communications@aaiusa.org



AN INCONVENIENT APOCALYPSE

ENVIRONMENTAL COLLAPSE,
CLIMATE CRISIS, AND THE FATE
OF HUMANITY

**WES JACKSON AND
ROBERT JENSEN**